

Fate's Edge

System Reference Document

May 27, 2026

Contents

1	Core Rules (Condensed)	10
1.1	The Core Resolution Loop	11
1.1.1	Difficulty Values (DV)	11
1.1.2	Position & Effect	11
1.1.3	Outcome Matrix	11
1.1.4	Boons	11
1.1.5	Story Beats (SB)	12
1.1.6	Description Ladder	12
1.2	Attributes & Skills	12
1.2.1	Attributes (1–5)	12
1.2.2	Skills (0–5)	12
1.3	Action Economy	12
1.3.1	Sidestep Strike	12
1.3.2	Shove	13
1.3.3	Grapple	13
1.3.4	Opportunity Attacks	13
1.3.5	Charge & Skirmish (Full Turn Actions)	13
1.4	Combat Basics	13
1.4.1	Range Bands	13
1.4.2	Hiding & Cover	14
1.4.3	Fatigue & Harm	14
1.5	Magic (Brief)	14
1.6	Travel Framework	15

1.7	Character Advancement	15
1.7.1	Starting Build	15
1.7.2	XP Awards (per session)	15
1.7.3	Spending XP	15
1.8	GM Quick Reference	15
2	Core Principles	16
2.1	What Is Fate’s Edge?	17
2.1.1	The Central Question	17
2.1.2	Tone of Play	17
2.2	The Core Loop in Micro-Examples	17
2.3	Key Concepts	17
2.3.1	Narrative Time	17
2.3.2	Story Beats (SB)	18
2.3.3	Affinity	18
2.3.4	Prestige Abilities	18
2.3.5	On-Screen vs. Off-Screen	18
2.4	Boons	18
3	Standard Rule: Player-Managed Modules	19
3.1	What Players Track	19
3.2	Procedure	20
3.3	Threshold Examples	20
3.4	Micro-Examples	20
3.5	Final Note	20
4	Core Mechanic	20
4.1	The Art of Consequence	20
4.2	Outcome Matrix	21
4.2.1	Anti-Fishing Measures	23
4.2.2	Boon Sharing	23
4.3	Story Beats (SB)	23
4.3.1	SB Spend Menu (guidance)	23
4.4	Critical Success	24

4.5	Position	24
4.5.1	Fatigue and Harm	24
4.6	Assistance, Boons, & Description	26
4.7	Time Guidance Framework	26
4.7.1	Narrative Time Scales	26
4.7.2	Game Structure Definitions	26
4.8	Fatigue	27
4.9	Initiative and Turn Order	27
4.10	Turn Economy (Quick Rules)	27
4.10.1	Magic and Ritual Time	30
4.11	Worked Micro-Examples	31
4.12	Session Loop	31
4.13	Small Folk of the Threshold (Aelaerem & Aelinnel)	31
5	Followers and Assets	32
5.1	Followers	32
5.2	Assets	33
5.3	Followers vs. Assets	34
5.4	High-Tier Play	34
6	Encounters	34
6.1	Common Framework	34
6.2	Clocks in Encounters	35
7	Combat Encounters	35
7.1	Rhythm of Battle	35
7.2	Health, Fatigue, and Harm	36
7.3	Weapons & Armor (Quick Reference)	37
8	Social Encounters	37
8.1	Setting Up	37
8.2	Non-Face Characters Can Help	37
8.3	Persuasion Rolls	38
9	Environmental Encounters	38

9.1	Terrain and Positioning	38
9.2	Hazards and Clocks	38
10	Magical Encounters (Brief)	39
10.1	Magic in Combat	39
10.2	Traps and Wards (Quick Look-up)	39
10.3	Summoning and Spirits (Quick Look-up)	39
10.4	Extended Rituals and Downtime Encounters	39
11	Quick Reference Table	39
12	Skills, Talents, and Equipment	40
12.1	Core Skills (Condensed)	40
12.2	Talents	41
12.3	Equipment	44
12.3.1	Weapons by Weight Class	44
12.3.2	Armor Conversion	44
12.3.3	Shields (Optional)	44
12.4	Equipment Condition & Upkeep	45
12.5	Magical Items (Enchantments)	45
12.6	Worked Example	45
13	The Magic System	46
13.1	Caster (Freeform / Weave & Cast)	46
13.2	Runekeeper (Rites)	46
13.3	Invoker (Symbols)	47
13.4	Cantor (Songs)	48
13.5	Sample Patrons and Rites (SRD Summary)	49
13.6	Elemental Backlash (Condensed)	50
13.7	Universal Rituals (Quick-Start)	50
13.8	TAGS System for Free Casting	51
13.9	Paths of Magic Comparison	51
14	Summoning	51
14.1	Who Can Summon?	51

14.2	Summoning for Narrative (Greater Powers)	52
14.3	PC Summoner (Pact-Whisperer)	52
14.3.1	Core Mechanics – Call, Bind, and the Leash	52
14.3.2	Sample Spirit Templates	54
14.4	GM Guidelines for Summoning	54
14.5	Summoning Talents (PC) Summary	55
15	Complications	55
15.1	Story Beats (SB)	55
15.2	Boons	56
15.3	Clocks as Complications	57
15.4	Hazards (Environmental, Social, Magical)	57
15.5	Fear Effects	58
15.6	The Deck of Consequences (Optional)	59
15.7	Integrating Complications with SB and Boons	60
15.8	Example: Complication in Action	60
16	Coordination Rules & Strategies	61
16.1	Purpose	61
16.2	Core Principles	61
16.3	Shared Vocabulary	61
16.4	Assistance (Baseline)	61
16.5	Position → DV	61
16.6	Bonds & Boon Sharing	62
16.7	Stacking Limits	62
16.8	Timing & Sequencing	62
16.9	Followers in Coordination	62
16.10	Cooperative Talents (Options)	62
16.11	GM Guidance (One Page)	63
16.12	Optional Rule: Multi-Character Followers	64
17	Rituals, Rites, and Invocations	65
17.1	Rituals (Universal)	65
17.2	Learned Rites (Runekeepers)	66

17.2.1 Rites Difficulty Value (DV)	66
17.3 Invokers and Symbols	66
17.4 Obligation Capacity and Clearing	66
17.5 Patron's Gift (Imbuement)	67
17.6 Borrowed Grace (Invoker Talent)	68
17.7 Mixing Paths	68
18 Tags & Effects Library	68
18.1 The Eight Elements	68
18.2 Effect Tags	69
18.3 How to Build a Spell	69
18.4 Example Spells	70
18.5 Control & Countermagic	70
18.6 Concealment & Revelation	71
18.7 Boons & Burdens	71
18.8 Influence & Oaths	72
18.9 Movement & Making	73
18.10 Outsider-Specific Tags	73
18.11 Elemental Backlash Coloring (Quick Reference)	74
18.12 Stacking & Duration Rules (Global)	74
19 Backlash, Obligation, and Ritual Consequences	74
19.1 Backlash (Free Casting)	75
19.2 Obligation (Rites and Patrons)	75
19.3 Ritual Consequences (Invokers and Universal Rituals)	76
19.4 Interruption and Counterplay	76
19.5 GM Budget Dials	76
19.6 Micro-Examples	77
20 Character Creation & Starting Build	77
20.1 Starting Build Points	77
20.2 Enhanced Starting Builds	77
20.3 Recommended Approach	77
20.4 Initial Complications (Reminder)	78

20.5 Early Talent Choices (Magic Access)	78
20.6 Quick Build Guides	78
20.7 Session Zero Tips	79
21 Advancement & XP	79
21.1 Awarding XP	79
21.1.1 Session Awards (Guidelines)	79
21.1.2 Milestones	80
21.1.3 Boon Conversion	80
21.2 Spending XP	80
21.3 Upkeep	80
21.4 Rush Rule	80
21.5 Tiers of Reputation	81
21.6 Advancement Notes	81
22 Range & Position Quick Reference	81
22.1 Range Bands	81
22.2 Movement (beats, not meters)	82
22.3 Melee Flag	82
22.4 Targeting & Tools (defaults)	82
22.5 Perception, Stealth, Cover	82
22.6 Position (Dominant / Controlled / Desperate)	82
22.7 GM Quick Cues	83
23 Travel Framework	83
23.1 Legs and Travel Clocks	83
23.2 Roles on the Road	83
23.3 Encounters & Events	84
23.4 Supply & Depletion	84
23.5 Optional: Regional Travel Decks	84
23.6 GM Quick Cues	85
24 Deck of Consequences (Optional)	85
24.1 Deck Structure	85

24.2 Card Ranks & Severity	85
24.3 Jokers (Optional)	85
24.4 When to Draw	86
24.5 Integration with Fiction	86
24.6 GM Quick Cues	86
25 Player Archetypes at the Table	86
25.1 The Solo	86
25.2 The Mixed	87
25.3 The Mastermind	87
25.4 Balancing Archetypes	87
25.5 GM Quick Cues	87
26 Campaign Frame: The Crown Spread (Optional)	87
26.1 Setup	88
26.2 Interpreting the Spread	88
26.3 Using the Spread in Play	88
26.4 Campaign Clock	88
26.5 Ending & Legacy	89
26.6 GM Quick Cues	89
27 Tags & Outcomes Cheat Sheet	89
27.1 Core Outcome Matrix	89
27.2 Common Tags (Abridged)	89
27.3 Position & Effect Shorthands	90
27.4 Backlash Reminders	90
27.5 Obligation Reminders	90
27.6 Magic Access Talent Costs (Quick Ref)	90
27.7 GM Quick Cues	90
28 Design Philosophy Guardrails (Flow-First GMing)	91
28.1 Simple Translations	91
28.2 The 30-Second Adjudication Loop	91
28.3 When to Reach for Mechanics (and When Not To)	91

28.4 Defaults That Keep Things Moving 92

28.5 Rookie GM Comfort Dials 92

28.6 Narrative-First Rulings (with Examples) 92

28.7 Let the Fiction Lead 92

28.8 Common Pitfalls and Fixes 93

28.9 The Four Questions (Cheat Prompts) 93

28.10Design Guardrails (for Consistency) 93

28.11Session Checklist (One Page) 94

1 Core Rules (Condensed)

Fate's Edge is a narrative-first TTRPG where every action has a cost, the fiction leads the rules, and tension is managed with **Position**, **Effect**, and **Story Beats (SB)**. This chapter gives you the complete table loop.

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

X-Card

Any player (including the GM) can draw an "X" on a card (or simply say "X") when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is **removed from the fiction** – no questions, no explanations, no judgments. You do not need to justify using the X-Card. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines

A **Line** is a hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: "No sexual violence," "No harm to children," "No body horror." Before the campaign or a session, players name their Lines. The GM and group honor them completely.

Veils

A **Veil** is a soft boundary: content that can happen "off screen" or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described in detail. Example: "A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit." Veils allow the story to acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use These Tools at Your Table

- Establish Lines and Veils during **Session Zero** (or before your first game). Write them down where everyone can see them.
- Keep an X-Card visible on the table (a printed card, a drawn X, or a digital symbol).
- Remind players they can use the X-Card at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, **pause**, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player who used it.
- The GM is also a player. The GM may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust that they had a good reason and support them.

Why These Tools Matter

These tools are not about censorship – they are about **consent**. They allow the group to tell darker, more intense stories together because everyone knows they can tap out at any time. A game that feels safe is a game that can go to the edge.

For more detail, see the X-Card by John Stavropoulos and the "Lines and Veils" RPG safety toolkit. Many free resources are available online.

1.1 The Core Resolution Loop

1. **Declare intent & approach** – What do you do? How?
2. **GM sets Position & DV** – Risk (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) and Difficulty Value (2–6).
3. **Roll dice** = Attribute + Skill (d10s). Each 6–10 = 1 success. Each 1 = 1 **Story Beat (SB)** for the GM.
4. **Compare successes to DV** – Use the Outcome Matrix.
5. **GM spends SB** to introduce complications, worsen Position, or tick clocks.

1.1.1 Difficulty Values (DV)

DV	Situation
2	Routine, low stakes
3	Default – pressured or minor opposition
4	Hard – hostile conditions
5+	Extreme – multiple constraints, dramatic failure

When in doubt, start at DV 3.

1.1.2 Position & Effect

- **Position** (risk): *Dominant* (safe), *Controlled* (balanced), *Desperate* (high stakes).
- **Effect** (reward): *Limited* (small), *Standard* (expected), *Great* (big).
- The GM sets both based on your approach and the fiction.

Improve Position: advantage, tools, or spend 1 Boon. *Worsen Position:* GM spends SB, alarms, exposure.

1.1.3 Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB=0	Clean Success – intent achieved
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB $\geq$ 1	Success & Cost – intent + complications
$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial – progress + complication; gain 1 Boon
Successes = 0	Miss – no progress; gain 2 Boons

1.1.4 Boons

- Earned on Miss (2) or Partial (1). Hold up to 5 (trim to 2 at scene end).
- **Spend 1 Boon to:** re-roll one die, activate an Asset, improve Position by one step.
- **Spend 2 Boons** → **1 XP** (max 2 XP/session).

1.1.5 Story Beats (SB)

GM resource. Spend SB to:

- **1 SB** – Minor: noise, trace, tick a 4/6 clock +1.
- **2 SB** – Moderate: lose Position, raise alarm, worse terms.
- **3 SB** – Serious: reinforcements, break an asset, split party.
- **4+ SB** – Major: authority arrives, environment shifts, Patron intervenes.

1.1.6 Description Ladder

How you describe your action adds optional re-rolls (all 1s still generate SB):

- **Basic:** roll as-is.
- **Detailed:** re-roll one die showing 1.
- **Intricate:** re-roll all 1s; add a flourish on success.

1.2 Attributes & Skills

1.2.1 Attributes (1–5)

Body (strength, endurance), **Wits** (perception, speed), **Spirit** (will, focus), **Presence** (charisma, command).

1.2.2 Skills (0–5)

Combat: Melee, Ranged, Brawl, Tactics.

Physical: Athletics, Stealth, Endurance, Craft, Survival.

Social: Sway, Command, Deception, Performance, Insight.

Knowledge: Lore, Investigation, Medicine.

Magic: Arcana, Ritual.

Roll Attribute + Skill dice. For a complete description of each skill, see the Player's Guide.

1.3 Action Economy

Each turn: **1 Action + 1 Move**. **Move** changes range band (Close ↔ Near ↔ Far) or repositions within same band. **Dash (Action):** move two bands; your next defense is Desperate. **Disengage (Action):** then your Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; you cannot Attack this turn.

1.3.1 Sidestep Strike

As part of a melee attack action, you may move one range band (Close ↔ Near, or Near ↔ Far) without using your Move action for the turn. If you do so, your Position for that attack worsens by

one step (e.g., Controlled becomes Desperate, Dominant becomes Controlled). You cannot also use your regular Move action in the same turn.

1.3.2 Shove

Action. Opposed **Body + Athletics** vs. target's **Body + Athletics**. On success, push the target back one range band (Close → Near). The target suffers −1 Position on their next action.

1.3.3 Grapple

Action. Opposed **Body + Melee** vs. target's **Body + Athletics**. On success, both characters are engaged (cannot move apart). The grappled target suffers −1 die on all actions. Breaking free requires a new opposed roll as an action.

1.3.4 Opportunity Attacks

If you move out of an enemy's **Close** range without using Disengage, that enemy may make one free melee attack against you (no action cost, Position Controlled). Additionally, the following actions provoke an opportunity attack if performed while engaged in Close with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack (bow, crossbow, thrown weapon).
- Casting a spell that does not have the [TOUCH] or [WARD] tag.

1.3.5 Charge & Skirmish (Full Turn Actions)

- **Charge:** move two bands toward an enemy and make one melee attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense Desperate. Requires open ground.
- **Skirmish:** move two bands away from an enemy and make one ranged attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense Desperate. Requires open ground.

Talents like Effortless Charge, Effortless Skirmish, and Relentless modify these actions.

1.4 Combat Basics

Initiative is narrative: GM spotlights based on fiction. Ambushers act first.

1.4.1 Range Bands

- **Close:** melee reach.
- **Near:** thrown weapons, short bows.
- **Far:** long range.
- **Absent:** off-screen (requires travel).

1.4.2 Hiding & Cover

To hide, be behind full cover (wall, large tree) and take the **Interact** action (Stealth vs Perception). Once hidden, you are not a valid target unless an enemy uses an action to **Search** (Perception vs your Stealth). Reveal yourself by attacking or moving into the open.

1.4.3 Fatigue & Harm

Fatigue track = Body. Mark Fatigue for exertion, backlash, or Charge/Skirmish. Each Fatigue worsens Position one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate). If already Desperate, each Fatigue gives −1 die instead.

Taking Harm Clears Fatigue (The Roller-Coaster Effect) When you take Harm, the shock of the wound temporarily clears your Fatigue. Follow this order:

1. Convert incoming Harm to Fatigue using the Armor Conversion table (see below).
2. Apply any remaining Harm – if Harm remains, clear all existing Fatigue, then increase your Harm level by the amount of Harm taken.
3. Add the Fatigue from step 1 to your Fatigue track. If this fills or exceeds your track, resolve overflow (increase Harm by 1, clear Fatigue).

Armor Conversion

Armor Type	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.

When Fatigue fills, increase Harm by 1 step and clear all Fatigue. **Harm levels:** 1 (−1 die), 2 (−1 die on most actions), 3 (incapacitated/dying). **Recovery:** Short rest clears 1–2 Fatigue; full night clears all; medical care reduces Harm.

1.5 Magic (Brief)

Three paths:

- **Caster (Freeform):** Requires *Spellcraft* talent. Weave elements + Channel power. DV = 1 + number of TAGS (dangerous TAGS +2 DV). Uses **Arcana** skill. On mixed result, Backlash relates to TAGS used.
- **Runekeeper:** Requires *Familiar* + *Codex*. Invoke Rites (1 action) and mark Obligation. Uses **Ritual** skill for rites that require a roll.

- **Invoker:** Requires *Patron's Symbol*. Rituals take time; *Crack the Seal* for instant cast (mark extra Obligation). Uses **Ritual** skill.

Cantors use **Performance** for Songs; Summoners use **Arcana** or **Ritual** as appropriate.

1.6 Travel Framework

Break journey into legs. Each leg has a **Travel Clock [4]**. Assign roles:

- **Guide:** reduces DV for movement checks.
- **Scout:** ignores next 1 SB spend.
- **Quartermaster:** reduces Supplies Clock by 1.
- **Watch:** starts next scene at Dominant.

Role actions require a roll (GM sets DV). Success advances clock or grants benefit. Complications may add segments.

1.7 Character Advancement

1.7.1 Starting Build

30 XP. Attributes 1–3, Skills 0–2. Bonds (+2 XP) and Complications (+4 XP) optional.

1.7.2 XP Awards (per session)

Standard 6–10; major objectives +2–4; discoveries +1–2; hard choices +1–2; arc milestones +8–12.

1.7.3 Spending XP

- New Attribute rating $\times 3$ XP.
- New Skill level $\times 2$ XP.
- Talents: see talent costs (2–12+ XP).
- Followers: Cap^2 XP.

1.8 GM Quick Reference

- **Default DV:** 3.
- **Position:** Controlled unless fiction says otherwise.
- **SB menu:** 1=minor, 2=moderate, 3=serious, 4+=major.
- **Clocks:** Keep at most three active (scene, journey, campaign).

Remember: Fail forward, let the fiction lead, spend SB to create momentum, and let players' choices reshape the world.

2 Core Principles

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

X-Card

Any player (including the GM) can draw an "X" on a card (or simply say "X") when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is **removed from the fiction** – no questions, no explanations, no judgments. You do not need to justify using the X-Card. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines

A **Line** is a hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: "No sexual violence," "No harm to children," "No body horror." Before the campaign or a session, players name their Lines. The GM and group honor them completely.

Veils

A **Veil** is a soft boundary: content that can happen "off screen" or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described in detail. Example: "A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit." Veils allow the story to acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use These Tools at Your Table

- Establish Lines and Veils during **Session Zero** (or before your first game). Write them down where everyone can see them.
- Keep an X-Card visible on the table (a printed card, a drawn X, or a digital symbol).
- Remind players they can use the X-Card at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, **pause**, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player who used it.
- The GM is also a player. The GM may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust that they had a good reason and support them.

Why These Tools Matter

These tools are not about censorship – they are about **consent**. They allow the group to tell darker, more intense stories together because everyone knows they can tap out at any time. A game that feels safe is a game that can go to the edge.

For more detail, see the X-Card by John Stavropoulos and the "Lines and Veils" RPG safety toolkit. Many free resources are available online.

2.1 What Is Fate's Edge?

Fate's Edge is a **narrative-first** tabletop roleplaying system where every action carries weight, every choice has consequence, and even failure feeds the story. Dice are not just success meters—they are instruments of fate, weaving opportunity with risk.

"The road is a ledger. Every broken wheel is a debt, every lit lamp a witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?"

2.1.1 The Central Question

What are you willing to risk, and what are you willing to pay, to reshape the world around you?

2.1.2 Tone of Play

- **Cinematic** – Scenes breathe, tense exchanges resolve in moments.
- **Consequential** – A whispered secret can topple a kingdom; a missed roll can spare a life.
- **Collaborative** – The GM sets stakes; the players drive the fiction.

2.2 The Core Loop in Micro-Examples

Before we dive into mechanics, see the rhythm in action:

[Lockpick Under Pressure] Lyra tries to pick a lock while a guard patrols nearby.

GM: "This is *Controlled*, DV 3. On a Miss, the guard hears you."

Lyra (Wits 2 + Tinker 2 = 4 dice): rolls 8, 6, 3, 1 → 2 successes (DV 3 → Partial), 1 SB.

GM: "The lock clicks open – but the last pin squeals. I spend 1 SB: the guard stops and tilts his head. You have one beat to hide."

[False Orders, Real Panic] Kael forges orders to redirect a patrol.

GM: "*Controlled*, DV 3. Subterfuge + Wits."

Kael (Wits 3 + Subterfuge 2 = 5 dice): rolls 9, 7, 5, 4, 2 → 3 successes, 0 SB. *Clean Success*.

GM: "The captain reads, nods, and marches his squad toward the west gate. You've bought minutes."

[From Dominant to Desperate] Sariel fires from behind a pillar (*Dominant Position*).

Roll: 6 dice → 10, 9, 7, 6, 3, 1 (1 SB). Clean hit.

GM spends 1 SB: "Return fire chips the pillar – your cover shrinks. Next action is *Controlled*." Later, after two more SB: "Reinforcements arrive – the scene drops to *Desperate*."

2.3 Key Concepts

2.3.1 Narrative Time

Measured by story weight, not minutes:

- **A Moment** – a heartbeat, a strike, a whispered word.
- **Some Time** – a skirmish, a tense negotiation.
- **Significant Time** – hours (travel, ritual).
- **Days** – marches, training, recovery.

2.3.2 Story Beats (SB)

Every time a player rolls a **1**, the GM gains a Story Beat. SB are narrative currency – spend them to introduce complications, escalate tension, or shift Position.

2.3.3 Affinity

Each culture grants an Affinity – a narrative edge or metaphysical bond that makes certain actions more reliable (e.g., Aeler stone-sense, Aelaerem hearth-luck). Affinities are described in the full Player’s Guide.

2.3.4 Prestige Abilities

High-level talents unlocked by mastering cultural or arcane arts. They are narrative milestones as much as mechanical upgrades.

2.3.5 On-Screen vs. Off-Screen

- **On-Screen:** followers, allies, companions who stand beside you.
- **Off-Screen:** assets, titles, informants, safe houses – resources that act when you spend Boons or during downtime.

2.4 Boons

Boons are narrative tokens earned primarily by failing rolls with meaningful consequences (see Outcome Matrix). They represent momentum, luck, or a second wind.

Earning Boons

- **Partial ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$):** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Miss ($\text{successes} = 0$):** Gain 2 Boons (provided the roll was meaningful and generated at least one Story Beat).
- **Bond-driven action:** Once per bond per session, when you act meaningfully on a Mutual Bond and provide an Intricate Description, gain 1 Boon.
- **GM award:** For creative solutions, sacrifices, or outstanding roleplay.

Spending Boons You may spend Boons on the following effects. Unless otherwise noted, each option costs 1 Boon.

- **Reroll a single die** after seeing the pool (you keep the second result; any new 1s generate additional Story Beats as normal).
- **Activate an on-screen Asset** (see Assets and Followers).
- **Improve Position** by one step before a roll (e.g., Controlled → Dominant).
- **Power certain Rites or abilities** as described in their text.
- **Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP** (once per session, during downtime; max 2 XP per session via conversion).

Substituting Fatigue for Boons If you have no Boons remaining (or wish to conserve them), you may pay **1 Fatigue** in place of 1 Boon to activate any effect that normally costs a Boon. This represents pushing through exhaustion, relying on raw effort, or accepting a minor physical toll. The GM may veto this substitution if the fiction makes it implausible (e.g., activating a delicate Asset while exhausted). Using this option does not change the effect's outcome or generate additional Story Beats; it simply changes the resource spent. *Design note: This rule ensures that players are never completely locked out of Boon-powered options, but the cost of Fatigue keeps it from being a free substitute.*

Limits

- Maximum 5 Boons held at any time.
- At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2 (excess are lost).
- At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene (repetition rule: same approach + same stakes cannot award another Boon).

3 Standard Rule: Player-Managed Modules

Players are the primary stewards of their **character-facing** modules (Obligation, Corruption, Leash, Asset States). This keeps the table moving and reduces GM overhead.

3.1 What Players Track

- **Obligation** (by Patron) – mark on Invoke/Push/ritual.
- **Corruption Clock** (Cantor) – mark on Push, Resonant Rite, or GM spending SB on occult actions.
- **Leash** (Summoning) – mark on spirit harm, unnatural commands, crossing wards.
- **Asset States** (Symbols, tools) – mark from maintenance or *Crack the Seal*.

GM retains all world-facing clocks and narrative fallout.

3.2 Procedure

- **Start of session:** announce current Obligation, Corruption, Leash, and any at-risk Assets.
- **End of scene:** "Any marks?" – players update modules; resolve thresholds immediately.
- **Downtime:** apply clears (service, purification, study) – GM verifies costs.

3.3 Threshold Examples

- **Obligation Capacity (Spirit+Presence):** Over capacity → +1 Fatigue per segment. Double capacity → clear all Fatigue, +1 Harm, Patron Intrusion.
- **Corruption Full:** gain last-Patron's boon & burden, reset clock.
- **Leash Full:** spirit acts once to its nature, then departs.
- **Symbol State:** COMPROMISED from *Crack the Seal* – repair in downtime or pay 1 XP.

3.4 Micro-Examples

- **Invoker, two rites:** Vessa Invokes two different Patrons – marks each Obligation separately. Hitting capacity with Patron A causes Fatigue; Patron B stays below.
- **Cantor Pushes:** Jorel Pushes a Song – marks +1 Corruption. That fills his clock; he immediately gains last-Patron's boon/burden, then resets to 0.
- **Summoner Clash:** Kestra's elemental takes Harm and crosses a ward – she ticks Leash twice. On fill, the elemental flares once and departs.

3.5 Final Note

The GM remains the arbiter of Patron intrusions, faction moves, and major narrative consequences. Player-managed modules keep the game fast and transparent, but the story's weight belongs to the whole table.

4 Core Mechanic

4.1 The Art of Consequence

Adjudicating Rolls: The Core Resolution Cycle When a player rolls, they are not simply trying to *beat a number*. They are engaging the world through risk, consequence, and discovery. This section walks through the full cycle.

Step-by-Step Roll Resolution

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Player states intent, Attribute + Skill.

2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes, not just mechanics.
3. **Establish Position:** GM sets whether the roll is **Dominant**, **Controlled**, or **Desperate**.
4. **Roll Pool of d10s.**
5. **Count: Successes (6+)** and **Story Beats (1s)**. Each **10** counts as two successes but does not auto-succeed if total < *DV*.
6. **Check Against DV:** Apply the Outcome Matrix.
7. **Spend SB:** GM spends/banks Story Beats or draws from the Deck of Consequences.

[Position Effects] IX

Position Effect

Dominant May re-roll one **failure** (die < 6).

Controlled Default state; no re-rolls.

Desperate Must re-roll one **success** (die 6+), keeping the second result.

Important: A roll showing a **10** is never re-rolled, even by Desperate position.

[Difficulty Ladder (Primary Guidance)] IX

DV Typical Case

- 2 Routine: trivial task, no pressure, almost guaranteed.
 - 3 Pressured: time limits, mild opposition, default for most rolls.
 - 4 Hard: hostile conditions, active resistance, precision required.
 - 5 Extreme: stacked constraints, high stakes, dramatic gambles.
 - 6+ Nearly impossible: mythic challenge, requires exceptional setup.
-

Optional: Opposed and Tier-Based DV

When a character directly opposes another (e.g., resisting a spell, contesting a grapple) or faces a threat whose Tier is known, the GM may use:

$$DV = \text{Defender's Tier} + 2 + \text{Modifiers}$$

Use the ladder above for all other rolls. The formula helps gauge elite challenges but should not replace the fiction-first ladder.

4.2 Outcome Matrix

[Outcome Matrix] IX

Result GM Guidance

$S \geq DV, C = 0$ Clean Success: Grant intent, no added friction.

$S \geq DV, C > 0$ Success & Cost: Intent achieved; GM spends SB for complications.

$0 < S < DV$ Partial: Progress *proportional* to hits; intent advances but with gaps or risk. Player gains 1 Boon.

$S = 0$ Miss: No progress. GM escalates with SB/Clocks. Player gains 2 Boons.

Fail Forward: Every Roll Matters Success. The action succeeds as intended. No Story Beats are generated unless specified by the roll or effect. The fiction advances cleanly in the player's favor.

Success with SB. The action succeeds, but generates **Story Beats**. The success stands; the cost is represented by the GM spending those Story Beats, ideally applied to the inciting action or its immediate consequences.

Miss. The action fails to achieve its intended effect and generates **Story Beats**. The GM uses those Story Beats to introduce complications, advance opposition, or shift the situation against the character.

Partial Success (GM Adjudication). A Partial indicates that the action makes progress, but does not fully resolve the situation. How that progress manifests is determined by the GM, based on context, scale, and narrative stakes.

Partial results may:

- Improve the character's **Position** on a follow-up attempt
- Reduce the effective **DV** of the next roll
- Achieve the goal at reduced scale or limited duration
- Succeed fully, but generate a **Story Beat** as cost or complication
- Reveal information or create a new opportunity instead of immediate resolution

Guiding Principle. Partials represent *meaningful progress*. The GM may convert progress into advantage, resolution, or complication, depending on what best serves the fiction.

One success on DV 4: "The lock is stubborn. You think you can get it if you keep trying."

Three successes on DV 4: "The lock springs open with a loud clank—you're sure the guards heard." (Upgrade to Success & Cost; add 2 SB).

Important Notes

- Rolling a 1 always creates SB for the GM. Rerolls do not erase SB.
- No Boons for rehearsal, trivial probes, or repeating an identical approach without changing fiction.
- Controlled tests with no bite give positioning/info, not Boons.

4.2.1 Anti-Fishing Measures

- **Cap:** At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene (further misses still make SB).
- **Repetition Rule:** Same action + same stakes in the same scene cannot grant another Boon.

Example Lockpicking under watch (*Desperate*, DV 3). **Miss:** GM spends 2 SB to start *Guards Incoming* [6]. Player earns 2 Boons. **Partial (2 successes):** Door opens halfway; guard footsteps approach. Player earns 1 Boon.

4.2.2 Boon Sharing

Players may gift **1 Boon per scene** to an ally with a brief narrative justification. A **bond** is a player-to-player agreement about shared history, loyalty, or obligation (see Character Creation). Bonded allies have a specific narrative tie.

- **Bonded Allies:** If characters share a bond, they may gift **2 Boons per scene**.
- **Assistance:** Boons may be spent to enhance an ally's roll (counts as assistance).
- **Campaign Events:** Major victories or setbacks may generate shared Boons for the party.

Table Use: Require a short story beat for each gift. Normal Boon limits apply. Track shared Boons openly. **GM Notes:** Reward generosity with extra opportunities, introduce occasional complications from dependence, and balance group vs. individual needs.

4.3 Story Beats (SB)

Story Beats (SB) are the engine of drama. They are not simple penalties, but narrative levers. The GM spends SB to introduce setbacks appropriate to the context:

- **Escalation** — drawing more enemies, raising the stakes.
- **Exhaustion** — draining time, resources, or positioning.
- **Exposure** — revealing hidden actions, alerting foes.
- **Collateral** — harm or danger spilling over onto allies, innocents, or surroundings.

4.3.1 SB Spend Menu (guidance)

- **1 SB:** Minor pressure: noise, trace, +1 segment on a relevant *scene clock*.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback: alarm raised, lose position/cover, lesser foe appears, or advance a **faction or front clock** by 1 segment.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble: reinforcements, key gear breaks, tick a campaign front.
- **4+ SB:** Major turn: trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts dramatically.

4.4 Critical Success

Rolling a **10** on any die indicates a critical tier of success. Each 10 adds weight to the outcome:

- **One 10:** Strong success with a free boon, improved Position, or other narrative flourish.
- **Two 10s:** Exceptional success; choose two benefits or a single powerful effect.
- **Three 10s:** Legendary success; resolve the conflict dramatically and progress or clear 1 segment on a secondary clock (generally, a clock tied to the scene, not the overarching campaign).
- **Four+ 10s:** Mythic success; progress or clear 1–2 segments from a secondary clock or create a significant story development.

If no 10s are rolled, resolve the action normally by the highest die result.

10s are never re-rolled by Position effects or other mechanics. Critical hit effects always take place if the roll is successful, despite any SB rolled. Critical successes may reduce Backlash/Obligation/Corruption severity by one tier.

4.5 Position

Every action in Fate’s Edge takes place from a **Position** that reflects the character’s advantage or disadvantage in the scene. Position sets the tone for the roll, narratively and mechanically. It comes in three states:

- **Dominant:** You act from a place of control, leverage, or overwhelming advantage.
- **Controlled:** The standard state of play. Outcomes are uncertain but balanced.
- **Desperate:** You act from dire straits, cornered or overmatched, with everything at stake.

Re-roll Mechanic. Position modifies the dice pool through simple re-rolls:

Position	Narrative Frame	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	You press your advantage	Re-roll one <i>failure</i>
Controlled	The balanced norm	No re-rolls
Desperate	You act under duress	Re-roll one <i>success</i>

Important: A roll showing a **10** is never re-rolled, even by Desperate position.

4.5.1 Fatigue and Harm

Fatigue. Fatigue is capped by **Body**. It reflects cumulative strain from combat, travel, or channeling. Fatigue never reduces dice directly; it shifts **Position** to riskier states.

Fatigue	Position Shift	Narrative Effect
1 (Winded)	Dominant → Controlled	Breathing heavy, off-balance.
2 (Strained)	Controlled rolls create +1 SB on 1s	Mistakes creep in.
3 (Exhausted)	Controlled → Desperate	Desperate exertion.
4 (Collapse)	DV 3 Body test or Severe Harm	Push past limits.

Harm Levels.

- **Harm 1:** –1 die on actions directly related to the injury (GM’s discretion).
- **Harm 2:** –1 die on most actions until treated.
- **Harm 3:** Incapacitated or dying.

Taking Harm Clears Fatigue (The Roller-Coaster Effect). When you take Harm, the shock of the wound temporarily clears your Fatigue. Follow this order:

1. Convert incoming Harm to Fatigue using the **Armor Conversion** table (see below).
2. Apply any remaining Harm – if Harm remains, clear all existing Fatigue, then increase your Harm level by the amount of Harm taken.
3. Add the Fatigue from step 1 to your Fatigue track. If this fills or exceeds your track, resolve overflow (increase Harm by 1, clear Fatigue).

Armor Conversion.

Armor Type	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.

Harm and Casting. Harm disrupts magical focus:

Harm	Casting Effect	Notes
Minor (Harm 1)	Channel DV +1	Fatigue of concentration.
Moderate (Harm 2)	Maintain channel DV 2	Focus falters.
Severe (Harm 2+ with narrative)	Channel breaks; freeform casting +1 SB	Magic slips dangerous.
Critical (Harm 3)	Casting impossible	Patron bargain may intervene.

GM Note: Harm and Fatigue push characters toward harsher Positions; casters feel this as *lost control*, warriors as *physical collapse*. Both create escalating drama without trivializing recovery.

Boon Interaction with Fatigue When Fatigue would force one or more success re-rolls:

- Spending **1 Boon** negates **one** Fatigue-imposed re-roll.
- Additional Fatigue re-rolls must be resolved normally.

Note: Boons may be spent **after seeing** the result of a Fatigue re-roll.

4.6 Assistance, Boons, & Description

- **Assists:** One helper per action; total Assist dice across sources are capped at +3 (unless a specific Talent states otherwise).
- **Boons:** A player may re-roll one die after seeing the pool. Once per session, in downtime, you may convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP via conversion per session). Hold cap: 5. Trim to 2 at scene end.
- **Description Ladder:**
 - **Basic:** No bonus.
 - **Detailed:** Re-roll one 1.
 - **Intricate:** Re-roll **up to two** 1s and add one narrative flourish on success (no extra mechanical benefit).

Maximum die pool An individual can have a max die pool of 10d10. All extra are converted to auto-successes.

4.7 Time Guidance Framework

4.7.1 Narrative Time Scales

Time in Fate's Edge is measured by story weight, not by clocks:

- **A Moment** — A heartbeat, a glance, a single strike or word.
- **Some Time** — A few minutes: a skirmish, a careful lockpick, a short negotiation.
- **Significant Time** — Hours: travel between locations, work a ritual, endure a siege.
- **Days** — Large-scale endeavors: marches across countryside, training a cadre, recovery.

4.7.2 Game Structure Definitions

Scene

The basic unit of narrative play (Some Time to Significant Time); resolves a specific question or conflict.

Player Turn (Beat)

Declare action → GM sets position → roll → resolve outcome → manage consequences.

Round

Simultaneous or near-simultaneous actions within a scene (primarily for combat), representing a few seconds.

Session

One complete game session (typically 3–6 hours), containing 2–4 major scenes and resolving significant narrative progress.

Campaign

Entire story arc (6–20+ sessions) with major character development and lasting consequences.

4.8 Fatigue

Track: Each character has a Fatigue track equal to **Body**. Mark Fatigue for exertion, strain, or backlash.

In Play: Each Fatigue step worsens your **Position** by one level (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate). If you are already **Desperate**, instead apply a **–1 die** penalty per Fatigue to that roll.

Overflow: When your Fatigue track fills, immediately increase **Harm by 1 step** and clear all Fatigue to 0. If this raises Harm to a level that incapacitates you, you fall out of the scene as normal for Harm.

Recovery: Short rest clears 1–2 Fatigue; a full night’s rest clears all Fatigue.

4.9 Initiative and Turn Order

Fate’s Edge does not use fixed initiative. Turn order follows the fiction and the GM’s facilitation:

- **Narrative Fiat:** The GM frames spotlight order based on circumstances, tension, and narrative flow.
- **Player Input:** Players may suggest acting when it makes sense in the fiction.
- **Surprise:** Ambushers act first; targets respond after the opening exchange.
- **Flexibility:** Spotlight may shift mid-scene if fictionally appropriate (e.g., reacting to a falling ceiling, seizing a moment).

This ensures pacing and drama guide the sequence of actions, not rigid turn structures.

4.10 Turn Economy (Quick Rules)

Two Actions. Each character takes **1 Action and 1 Move** on their turn. Actions and Moves may be taken in any order; repeating the same Action is not allowed unless noted. A character may use a Boon to re-roll their action at the expense of their move if they still have it available. Some weapon tempos affect whether you can take an attack and a move.

Move. Traverse up to one range band (Close → Near → Far, or vice versa). You may also use your Move to reposition within the same range band (e.g., from behind one tree to another at the same distance). This does not change your range band but may affect cover or line of sight.

- **Stand:** Use your Move to stand from prone.
- **Dash:** You may *use your Action to gain an extra Move* (see below). Dashing allows you to move two bands total in your turn. Your next defense roll is **Desperate**.

Sidestep Strike. As part of a melee attack action, you may move one range band (Close ↔ Near, or Near ↔ Far) without using your Move action for the turn. If you do so, your Position for that attack worsens by one step (e.g., Controlled becomes Desperate, Dominant becomes Controlled). You cannot also use your regular Move action in the same turn.

Shove. Action. Opposed **Body** + **Athletics** vs. target's **Body** + **Athletics**. On success, push the target back one range band (Close → Near). The target suffers -1 Position on their next action.

Grapple. Action. Opposed **Body** + **Melee** vs. target's **Body** + **Athletics**. On success, both characters are engaged (cannot move apart). The grappled target suffers -1 die on all actions. Breaking free requires a new opposed roll as an action.

Opportunity Attacks. Moving out of an enemy's **Close** range without using the **Disengage** action provokes an immediate free melee attack from that enemy. The attack is resolved normally (Position usually Controlled). This attack does not consume the enemy's action for the round.

Additionally, the following actions provoke an opportunity attack if performed while engaged in Close with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack (bow, crossbow, thrown weapon).
- Casting a spell that does not have the [TOUCH] or [WARD] tag.

Hiding and Cover. To hide, a character must be behind full cover (e.g., a large tree, a wall) or in heavy concealment (dense fog, darkness). They must take the **Interact** action to hide, rolling Stealth (or appropriate skill) vs. the Perception of any observers. Once hidden, they are not a valid target for attacks unless an attacker first uses an action to **Search** (Perception vs. the hidden character's Stealth) or the hidden character reveals themselves by attacking or moving into the open.

If a hidden character moves out of cover to attack, they are no longer hidden for the duration of the attack, and may be subject to opportunity attacks if they leave an enemy's Close range.

Action Options.

- **Attack.** Make a melee or ranged attack versus DV set by the GM and fiction. Ranged attacks made while within **Close** range of an enemy are **Desperate** (re-roll successes). Teamwork/Assist costs 1 Boon.

- **Disengage. Action, not a Move.** You prepare to retreat safely. After taking Disengage, your **Move** this turn does not provoke opportunity attacks. You cannot also **Attack** this turn.
- **Charge.** *Full turn action.* Move up to two range bands (e.g., Far → Near → Close) and make one melee attack. Costs **1 Fatigue**. Your next defense is Desperate. Consumes both your Action and Move. Requires open ground (no difficult terrain). **Important:** If your target is hidden (e.g., behind full cover), you cannot complete the Charge because you have no valid target. You may instead move up to the cover and end your turn there. The attack is lost.
- **Skirmish.** *Full turn action.* Move up to two range bands away (e.g., Close → Near → Far) and make one ranged attack. Costs **1 Fatigue**. Your next defense is Desperate. Consumes both Action and Move. Requires open ground. If you start your turn hidden, you may Skirmish: you leave cover, move, shoot, and may end your turn in new cover if available. You are exposed during the movement and the shot; opportunity attacks apply normally if you leave an enemy's Close range.
- **Observe / Change Position.** Take a beat to read the field or set angles; gain **+1 Position** for one action this turn (e.g., Controlled → Dominant). Limit: once/turn; cannot exceed **Dominant**.
- **Setup (Teamwork).** Create advantage for an ally; on success, grant their next action **+1 Position** or step up Effect (GM's call).
- **Assist (Teamwork).** Spend *1 Boon* to give an ally *+1 die* on their current roll; you share appropriate risk/consequence.
- **Protect.** Adopt a guarding stance or body-block. Choose a nearby ally; until your next turn you may intercept one hit on them and roll to resist it. On success, reduce/negate Harm; you take any fallout the GM assigns.
- **Channel / Weave.** Runekeeper/ritual flow: *Channel* (prime power) then *Weave* (shape/release). Disruption or engagement may worsen Position; if *Interrupted*, the casting fails.
- **Cast Rite / Song (Cantor).** Perform a Rite/Song per its write-up. You may *Push* to accelerate or empower at the cost of Fatigue/Corruption per class rules.
- **Interact.** Lift, pull, flip a lever, shove a foe, break an object, apply a poultice, reload, draw/stow, or **hide / search**. GM sets DV/Effect.
- **Defend.** Spend your Action or Move to enter a defensive stance. Until your next turn, you count as Defending. When resisting any attack or effect, improve your Position by one step (or gain **+1 die** if already Dominant).
- **Free Items.** Short shouts, dropping an item, quick glance. Longer or tactical assessments require *Observe / Change Position* or *Interact*.
- **Reactions (Out of Turn).** *Protection* may trigger when an ally is hit and you are in position. Class/Asset reactions fire as written (e.g., counter-runes, ripostes). Opportunity attacks are a free reaction that any creature can take when an enemy leaves its Close range without Disengaging.

Position and Dice Modifiers. There is no hard cap at Dominant or Desperate. Instead:

- If bonuses would raise your Position above **Dominant**, each additional step becomes **+1 die** instead.
- If penalties would drop your Position below **Desperate**, each additional step becomes **-1 die** instead.
- **Example:** You have two sources of Position improvement. Dominant → would be step 1, step 2 would be **+1 die**. If you are already at Desperate and a penalty would push you lower, you suffer **-1 die** per step.

This allows unlimited stacking of dice modifiers while keeping the three Position tiers meaningful.

Open Ground Requirement. The **Charge** and **Skirmish** actions require **open ground** (no difficult terrain such as rubble, dense forest, shallow water, or steep slopes). Talents may override this restriction.

Example Talents (for reference).

- **Effortless Charge** (4 XP): Once per scene, you may Charge without marking Fatigue.
- **Effortless Skirmish** (4 XP): Once per scene, you may Skirmish without marking Fatigue.
- **Relentless** (6 XP): You may Charge or Skirmish over difficult terrain (Fatigue cost still applies).
- **Stubborn Pursuer** (6 XP): When an opponent within Close range Disengages, you may use your reaction to move with them, staying in Close range (no opportunity attack provoked).

4.10.1 Magic and Ritual Time

- **Standard Casting:** Channel and Weave phases each take 1 Player Turn; resolves within a single scene.
- **Ritual Casting (Optional Rule):** Channel and Weave phases each require 1 Scene (Significant Time).
- **Rites Invocation:** Invoke takes 1 Player Turn; Weave takes 1 Player Turn. High-Power rites may require extended time by fiction.

Extended Rituals Attach long rituals to clocks:

- 4-segment clock: Significant Time (hours)
- 6-segment clock: Extended Time (days)
- 8+ segment clock: Campaign Time (weeks/months)

Advance the clock through player actions, scenes, or set intervals.

4.11 Worked Micro-Examples

- **Lockpick Under Watch (DV 3):** Roll 6 dice: 10, 8, 5, 4, 1, 1 $\Rightarrow S = 2$ (10 counts as two successes), $C = 2$. *Success & Cost.* Door opens; GM spends 1 SB for a squeal (patrol starts moving) and banks 1 SB to bring that patrol around on the next beat.
- **Charm the Captain (DV 2):** Roll 5 dice: 7, 6, 6, 2, 1 $\Rightarrow S = 3, C = 1$. *Success & Cost.* Passage granted; GM spends 1 SB: "He expects a favor on the return leg—he'll collect."
- **Traverse the Pass (DV 3):** Group pools to net 3 successes but produces $C = 3$. *Success & Cost.* GM spends 2 SB to add Fatigue 1 to all from cold and exposure, banks 1 SB to crack a wagon axle next scene.

Fail Forward: Every Roll Matters When you **MISS** on a *meaningful action*, you gain 2 **Boons**. When you have a **PARTIAL**, you gain 1 **Boon**. Boons can be spent immediately for re-rolls, Asset activations, Rites, and other abilities. You can hold up to 5 Boons (trim to 2 at scene end).

A miss only awards Boons if all three are true:

1. Procedure followed: intent and approach declared; DV set; roll resolved.
2. Stakes stated: what changes on success; what bites on failure.
3. Consequence lands now: the GM spends or banks SB, applies a condition, or advances a thread.

Typically, failures reward boons. Rehearsal/null-risk probes and repeated identical attempts in the same scene do not award Boons. Rule of thumb, if it feels like an obvious fishing attempt, do not award a boon.

4.12 Session Loop

Off-Screen (Downtime). Clear/mark clocks, pay Upkeep, manage Obligation, craft, gather info, frame intents.

On-Screen (Adventure). Play scenes, make moves, trigger Rites/Casting, advance fronts.

Wrap-Up. Award XP, mark Story Beats (SB), resolve Harm/Fatigue conversion, advance faction clocks, note Patron Largess.

Off-Screen Hooks. Record next Downtime intents (projects, service to Patrons, upkeep needs) and any cliffhangers.

4.13 Small Folk of the Threshold (Aelaerem & Aelinnel)

The Aelaerem and Aelinnel are diminutive peoples attuned to liminal spaces and hidden ways. Their stature grants them agility and subtlety, though at the cost of bearing heavy arms or armor.

- **Restriction:** Cannot use *Heavy Armor* or *Heavy Weapons*.

- **Bonus:** Gain +1 **Position** when avoiding physical harm (e.g., dodging an attack, leaping from an explosion, resisting a shove). Additionally, gain +1 **die** on *Hide* or *Evasion* rolls made while in cover.

Their presence in the world is often underestimated, but their knack for slipping unseen through thresholds and enduring where others falter has earned them a quiet reverence.

5 Followers and Assets

Followers and Assets represent the lasting impact of your character's actions on the world. They are not abstractions or passive bonuses—they are *people, resources, and structures* that exist in the fiction and can act independently of your character.

Together, Followers and Assets allow characters to project influence beyond a single roll or scene, shaping the world through relationships, preparation, and legacy.

5.1 Followers

Followers are named NPCs who have a personal relationship with your character. They may be students, allies, retainers, agents, family members, or dependents. Followers act in the fiction and can grow, change, or be lost as the story progresses.

What Followers Do Followers:

- Assist you during scenes through **Bonds** and **Assists**
- Act offscreen to advance goals, gather information, or manage responsibilities
- Accumulate narrative weight and may eventually become player characters

Followers are not disposable tools. They have motives, limitations, and vulnerabilities, and the GM may place them at risk when the fiction demands it.

Using Followers Followers typically influence play in three ways:

- **Assists:** Granting +1 die or narrative positioning when they are present and able to help
- **Bond Activation:** Spending a Boon to draw on trust, loyalty, or shared history for insight or support
- **Offscreen Action:** Handling tasks that would otherwise demand the PC's time or attention

Limits Followers:

- Do not replace player actions
- Do not make rolls unless the GM explicitly calls for it
- Cannot solve major conflicts without consequences

When Followers succeed or fail, those outcomes become part of the story.

5.2 Assets

Assets are durable resources, positions, or structures under your character's control. They represent *leverage*—things that allow you to influence the world at scale.

Examples include:

- A safehouse, laboratory, or fortress
- A mercantile network or smuggling route
- A political office or religious authority
- A powerful relic, symbol, or institutional role

What Assets Do Assets:

- Create advantages that persist beyond a single scene
- Resolve problems that cannot be solved with a single roll
- Shape the direction and scope of the campaign

Assets are not passive bonuses. They matter only when invoked in the fiction.

Activating Assets Most Assets require the expenditure of **Boons** to activate.

When you spend a Boon on an Asset, you may:

- Advance or halt a Clock
- Introduce or remove a complication
- Secure resources, protection, or access
- Influence events happening offscreen

The GM determines the exact impact based on the scale of the Asset and the current situation.

Assets and Risk Assets can be threatened, degraded, or lost.

- Overuse attracts attention
- Failure creates new problems
- Enemies may target your Assets directly

An Asset that never faces risk is not part of the story.

5.3 Followers vs. Assets

	Followers	Assets
Nature	People	Resources / Structures
Primary Role	Personal support	Strategic leverage
Activation	Assists, Bonds	Boon expenditure
Risk	Emotional and narrative	Structural and political
Growth	Can become PCs	Can expand or collapse

Design Principle Followers create *depth*. Assets create *reach*.

High-tier play depends less on raw die bonuses and more on how well you manage both.

5.4 High-Tier Play

As characters advance, Followers and Assets become increasingly important. Higher-tier Talents and Assets consume Boons, forcing players to choose between immediate success and long-term influence.

Power at high tier is not about having more Boons—it is about deciding where to spend them.

Victory is no longer just surviving the roll. It is choosing which parts of the world move when you do.

Mounted Combat (Simplified). If you have a **War Mount** and the **Cavalier** talent:

- Charging into melee from **Far** → **Near**: +2d
- Firing while disengaging **Near** → **Far**: +2d

The bonus applies only when movement is part of the action. Misses and Partial successes often cost mount Fatigue, equipment damage, or narrative complications.

6 Encounters

All encounters – combat, social, environmental, magical – use the same core engine: **Position**, **Effect**, **DV**, **Boons**, and **Story Beats (SB)**. Clocks track progress toward resolution.

6.1 Common Framework

- **State Intent & Approach.** What do you want to achieve, and how?
- **Set Position & DV.** GM determines risk (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) and difficulty (2–7+).
- **Roll Attribute + Skill.** Each 6+ = success; each 1 = SB for the GM.
- **Apply Outcome.** Use the Outcome Matrix (Clean Success, Success & Cost, Partial, Miss).
- **Spend SB.** GM introduces complications, shifts Position, or advances clocks.

6.2 Clocks in Encounters

Clocks track cumulative progress or increasing pressure:

- **Progress Clock (4–8 segments):** Fill to succeed (e.g., persuasion, escaping a maze).
- **Threat Clock (4–8 segments):** Fill to trigger a disaster (e.g., reinforcements, structural collapse).
- **Contest Clocks:** Two clocks – one for each side; first to fill wins.

Tick clocks on **Partial** (1 tick) or **Clean Success** (2 ticks). Misses may tick opposition clocks.

7 Combat Encounters

7.1 Rhythm of Battle

No fixed initiative. GM spotlights based on fiction. Each turn: **1 Action + 1 Move**.

Movement Basics

- **Move:** Shift one range band (Close↔Near↔Far) or reposition within same band.
- **Dash (Action):** Move two bands; your next defense is *Desperate*.
- **Disengage (Action):** Then your Move does not provoke opportunity attacks. You cannot Attack this turn.

Opportunity Attacks

Leaving an enemy's **Close** range without *Disengage* provokes one free melee attack (*Controlled Position*, no action cost). Additionally, the following actions provoke an opportunity attack if performed while **engaged in Close** with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack (bow, crossbow, thrown weapon).
- Casting a spell that does **not** have the [TOUCH] or [WARD] attribute.

The attacker makes one free melee attack at *Controlled Position*.

Charge & Skirmish (Full Turn Actions)

- **Charge:** Move two bands toward an enemy and make one melee attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense *Desperate*. Requires open ground.
- **Skirmish:** Move two bands away from an enemy and make one ranged attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense *Desperate*. Requires open ground.

Talents (e.g., *Effortless Charge*, *Relentless*) modify these.

7.2 Health, Fatigue, and Harm

Fatigue Track

- **Track size** = **Body** (minimum 1).
- Mark Fatigue from exertion (Charge/Skirmish, forced marches, magic costs, Obligation overflow).
- **Effect of Fatigue:** Each point of Fatigue worsens your **Position** by one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate). If already *Desperate*, each additional Fatigue instead imposes a **−1 die penalty** on all your rolls.
- Penalties from Fatigue and Harm **stack**.

Harm Levels

Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	−1 die on actions directly related to the injury (GM’s discretion).
Harm 2	−1 die on most actions until treated.
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying.

Taking Harm and Fatigue – The Procedure When you are hit, follow these steps **in order**:

1. **Convert** – Use the Armor Conversion Table to turn incoming Harm into Fatigue. Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.
2. **Apply remaining Harm** – *First:* If any Harm remains, clear all existing Fatigue (the shock of a wound resets exhaustion). *Then:* Increase your Harm level by the number of Harm points remaining.
3. **Apply Fatigue** from step 1. If this fills your Fatigue track, resolve Overflow (see below).

Table 1: Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Conversion Rule	Minimum Fatigue
Light	Convert 1 Harm → 1 Fatigue; rest is Harm.	1
Medium	Convert 2 Harm → 1 Fatigue; rest is Harm.	1
Heavy	Convert 3 Harm → 2 Fatigue; rest is Harm.	1

Overflow (Fatigue Track Fills)

- Add Fatigue first; then, if the track is full (or would exceed its size):
 1. Increase **Harm** by one level.
 2. **Clear all Fatigue**.
 3. Any excess Fatigue beyond the track size is lost.
- This can happen multiple times in one hit (e.g., with Body 1 or 2).

Examples

- **Light Armor, Harm 2:** Convert $1 \rightarrow 1$ Fatigue, remaining Harm 1. Apply Harm (clears Fatigue, Harm $0 \rightarrow 1$), then add 1 Fatigue. Result: Harm 1, Fatigue 1.
- **Heavy Armor, Harm 3:** Convert $3 \rightarrow 2$ Fatigue, remaining Harm 0. No Harm taken, add 2 Fatigue. Result: Fatigue +2.
- **Heavy Armor, Harm 1:** Convert $1 \rightarrow 0$ Fatigue, but minimum 1 Fatigue. No Harm. Result: Fatigue +1.
- **Overflow:** Body 2, currently 1 Fatigue, Heavy Armor hit with Harm 3. Convert $3 \rightarrow 2$ Fatigue. Add Fatigue: $1+2 = 3$, track full. Overflow triggers: Harm $0 \rightarrow 1$, clear Fatigue. Result: Harm 1, Fatigue 0.

Recovery

- **Fatigue:** Short rest removes 1–2 Fatigue; full night removes all.
- **Harm:** Requires medical care (Medicine roll) or magical healing.

7.3 Weapons & Armor (Quick Reference)

Weapon Type	Close	Near	Tempo
Light	+2 dice	+1 dice	Fast
Medium	+1 dice	+2 dice	Standard
Heavy	–1 dice	+3 dice	Slow

Armor uses the conversion table above. Shields and weapon tags (Accurate, Brutal, etc.) are optional.

8 Social Encounters

Use **Persuasion Clocks** for extended negotiations, debates, or intimidation.

8.1 Setting Up

- **Target's Resolve:** Easy (4-segment), Moderate (6-segment), Hard (8-segment).
- **Initial Position:** Based on relationship, leverage, and setting (Dominant = mutual trust, Desperate = hostile audience).
- **DV:** Standard ladder (3–7+) with modifiers for cultural gaps, time pressure, etc.

8.2 Non-Face Characters Can Help

- **Setup:** Create an advantage – produce evidence, cause a distraction, or perform a display of force. Roll an appropriate skill. On success, grant the primary speaker +1 Position or +1 die.

- **Assist:** Spend 1 Boon to give +1 die (narrated as a timely interjection or meaningful glance).
- **Interrupt:** On a Miss, a non-face character can take the fallout (e.g., absorb a social rebuke) by marking 1 Fatigue.

8.3 Persuasion Rolls

Each distinct argument or lever advances the clock:

- **Clean Success:** +2 segments.
- **Partial:** +1 segment; GM may spend SB for a complication (e.g., "They agree, but you'll owe a favor").
- **Miss:** No progress; GM may tick an **Opposition Clock** (4–6 segments).

When the Opposition Clock fills, the target hardens – Position worsens or the ask becomes impossible. When the Persuasion Clock fills, the target agrees as framed.

9 Environmental Encounters

9.1 Terrain and Positioning

- **Height Advantage:** +1 die or +1 Effect for attacks from above.
- **Cover:** Partial cover (+1 DV to target you); Full cover (cannot be targeted directly). You may **Hide** behind full cover (Stealth vs Perception).
- **Difficult Terrain:** Costs **2 Move actions** to traverse one band (or a full action to Dash). Charge/Skirmish require open ground unless the *Relentless* talent is used.

9.2 Hazards and Clocks

Active hazards (fire, flooding, toxic gas) are represented by **Threat Clocks**:

- Tick the clock on missed rolls, GM SB spends, or at scene intervals.
- When the clock fills, the hazard triggers (e.g., collapse, wave of fire).
- Characters may attempt to **slow** or **disable** the hazard (e.g., Tinker to seal a gas leak, Magic to freeze spreading flames). Treat as a **Progress Clock**.

Example: Collapsing Bridge [6] – ticks on each Partial or Miss. At 3 segments, footing becomes Desperate; at 6, the bridge falls.

10 Magical Encounters (Brief)

10.1 Magic in Combat

Caster (Freeform) Weave then Cast (2 actions). Push (mark Fatigue) to compress to 1 action. Casting while Engaged worsens Position by one step unless spell has [TOUCH] or [WARD].

Runekeeper Invoke a Rite as 1 action; mark Obligation. Push It (+1 Obligation).

Invoker Ritual takes DV+1 rounds. *Crack the Seal* (instant) marks +2 Obligation, Symbol Compromised.

Cantor Sing a Song (1 action, resolves next turn). Push to resolve immediately (mark Corruption).

10.2 Traps and Wards (Quick Look-up)

- **Discover:** Notice vs DV 4–6.
- **Disable:** Contested roll trap's tick. Clean Success = neutralized; Partial = disable but generate SB; Miss = trap activates.
- **Activation:** GM spends SB to trigger trap (damage, condition, clock advance).
- **Wards:** Magical barriers with a DV (3–6). Crossing without dispelling triggers the effect and ticks any relevant **Leash** by the ward's DV.

10.3 Summoning and Spirits (Quick Look-up)

- **Leash:** Cap + Spirit segments.
- **Ticks:** Spirit takes harm (1 per Harm level); acts against nature (1); crosses a ward without dispelling (ticks = ward's DV).
- **Leash fills:** Spirit acts once to its nature (potentially hostile) then departs.
- **Boons:** Summoner may spend 1 Boon to clear 1 tick (once per round).

10.4 Extended Rituals and Downtime Encounters

Use a **Progress Clock** (4–12 segments). Each segment represents a scene or a block of time. Players describe their approach and roll an appropriate skill; success advances the clock. Complications (GM SB) may add segments, require rare components, or draw unwanted attention.

11 Quick Reference Table

	Encounter	DV (Default)	Typical Skills	Common Clocks
Combat	3 (Controlled)	Melee, Ranged, Athletics, Command	Mob Overwhelm [6], Fatigue Spiral [4]	
Social	3 (Controlled)	Sway, Subterfuge, Insight, Command	Persuasion [4–8], Opposition [4]	
Environmental	3–4 (varies)	Athletics, Survival, Tinker, Stealth	Collapse [6], Flood [6], Chase [4]	
Magical	4–6 (specific)	Arcana, Lore, Spirit+Resolve	Leash [Cap+Spirit], Ritual [6–12]	

GM Reminders

- **Let non-specialists contribute** – use Setup and Assist actions, and allow creative skill use.
- **Spend SB to escalate, not punish.** A well-spent SB changes the situation, creating new choices.
- **Clocks make progress visible.** When a clock ticks, describe what changes in the fiction.
- **Armor & Fatigue:** Follow the step-by-step procedure: convert, apply remaining Harm (clears existing Fatigue), then add Fatigue. Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.

12 Skills, Talents, and Equipment

12.1 Core Skills (Condensed)

An action roll pairs an **Attribute** with a **Skill**. The GM sets Position and DV from the fiction. Core skills include:

- **Combat:** Melee, Ranged, Brawl, Tactics.
- **Physical:** Athletics, Stealth, Endurance, Craft, Survival.
- **Social:** Sway, Command, Deception, Performance, Insight.
- **Knowledge:** Lore, Investigation, Medicine.
- **Magic:** Arcana, Ritual.
- **Arcana** – magic theory, wards, free casting, counter-spelling.
- **Endurance** – resisting fatigue, poison, harsh weather.
- **Athletics** – running, climbing, jumping, swimming.
- **Insight** – reading emotions, detecting lies, understanding motives.
- **Brawl** – unarmed combat, grappling, improvised weapons.
- **Investigation** – research, deduction, analysis of clues.
- **Command** – leadership, intimidation, issuing orders.
- **Lore** – history, culture, religion, customs, local knowledge.
- **Craft** – building, repairing, creating tools or structures.
- **Medicine** – healing, anatomy, first aid, surgery.
- **Deception** – lying, bluffing, misdirection, forgery.
- **Melee** – swords, axes, close-quarters weapons.
- **Performance** – singing, acting, oration, musi-

cal display.

- **Ranged** – bows, crossbows, thrown weapons.
- **Ritual** – performing rites, invocations, exorcisms, consecrations.
- **Stealth** – moving unseen, hiding, camouflage.
- **Survival** – tracking, foraging, predicting weather, navigating wilderness, animal handling.
- **Sway** – persuasion, negotiation, charm.
- **Tactics** – battlefield strategy, unit coordination, ambush planning.

Note: **Survival** replaces *Nature*, covering all wilderness and animal interactions. **Insight** replaces *Notice* for social perception; use **Investigation** for physical clue-finding. **Ritual** is for actively performing magic (Rites, Songs, invocations); **Arcana** covers theory and identification. Optional modules (e.g., *Psionics*) may add additional skills.

Common uses: Use **Craft** for mechanical locks and traps; **Arcana** or **Lore** for magical wards. **Sway** gets you past people; **Stealth** and **Craft** get you through mechanisms.

12.2 Talents

Talents are the building blocks of character specialization. Each costs XP. **Passive** talents are always on; **active** talents require an action or reaction and cannot be used simultaneously unless noted. This list covers the core archetypes; many more exist in the full guides.

Talent Costs

- 2–3 XP: Minor edge (small bonus, once per scene).
- 4–6 XP: Major edge (permanent +1 die in a niche, access to magic).
- 7–10 XP: Prestige (campaign-defining).
- 11+ XP: Epic (legendary, story-shaping).

Magic Access Talents

- **Spellcraft (6 XP)** – enables freeform casting.
- **Familiar (2 XP)** – required for Patron’s Gift, binds a Thiasos.
- **Codex (4 XP)** – needed for Runekeeper Rites and Obligation.
- **Patron’s Symbol (4 XP)** – allows Invoker rituals.
- **Cantor’s Path (8 XP)** – allows Songs (Corruption track).
- **Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)** – base summoning access.

Striker (Melee/Ranged Damage)

- **Weapon Master (5 XP):** +2 dice with a chosen weapon; once/scene +1 Effect with that weapon. *Passive + active.*

- **Flurry Strike (6 XP)**: Make two attacks as one action (each −1 die). *Active, once/scene.*
- **Duelist's Edge (6 XP)**: +1 die when engaged with a single opponent; ignore the first Harm 1 or 2 from that opponent once/scene. *Passive + active.*
- **Backstab (6 XP)**: When attacking from stealth, deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 point of Armor. *Active, once/scene.*
- **Shadow Dance (10 XP)**: After a successful Backstab, test Stealth to re-enter stealth; on success, clear 1 Fatigue or improve Position by 1. *Active, once/scene.*
- **Effortless Charge (4 XP)**: Ignore the Fatigue cost of Charge once/scene.
- **Effortless Skirmish (4 XP)**: Ignore the Fatigue cost of Skirmish once/scene.
- **Relentless (6 XP)**: May Charge or Skirmish over difficult terrain (Fatigue cost still applies). *Passive.*

Defender (Tank, Protection)

- **Defensive Survival (3 XP)**: +1 die to defense rolls while engaged in melee; once/scene convert Harm 1 from melee to Fatigue. *Passive + active.*
- **Conditioning (4 XP)**: Body counts as +1 for Fatigue track; +1 die to resist Fatigue overflow effects. *Passive.*
- **Tactical Movement (4 XP)**: May move within engagement range as a Move action (instead of full action); once/scene disengage from Close as a Move action. *Passive + active.*
- **Protect (action)**: Any character can use the *Protect* action (see Action Options); no talent required.
- **Stubborn Pursuer (6 XP)**: When an opponent within Close range Disengages, you may use your reaction to move with them, staying in Close range. *Reactive.*

Controller (Area, Debuff, Terrain)

- **Battlefield Mastery (6 XP)**: When engaged with 3+ opponents, for 3 exchanges: melee attacks gain +1 Effect, enemies act at −1 die, your Position improves by one step, and you may convert one Harm 1 per exchange to Fatigue. *Active, once/scene.*
- **Spellcraft (6 XP)**: Enables freeform spellcasting (see Magic section). Use [TAGS] to create area effects, binds, walls, etc.
- **Ritual Mastery (4 XP)**: Reduce casting time for major rituals by half; GM banks 1 SB on any ritual backlash. *Passive.*

Support (Healing, Buffs, Teamwork)

- **Field Dressing (2 XP)**: When an ally would take Harm that would incapacitate them, you may use your reaction to stabilize them; they remain at Harm 2 instead of 3 for the scene. *Active, once/scene.*

- **Medic's Hand (3 XP):** When you stabilize an ally, also clear 1 Fatigue or downgrade Harm 2→1. Spend 1 Boon to do both. *Reactive.*
- **Inspire (3 XP):** Once/scene, spend 1 Boon and choose: a bonded ally gains +1 Boon and +1 die on their next roll; or all allies in Near gain +1 die on their next roll. *Active.*
- **Setup (action):** Any character can use the *Setup* action (see Action Options); no talent required.
- **Command Presence (4 XP):** +1 die on leadership and intimidation rolls. *Passive.*

Scout (Stealth, Infiltration, Awareness)

- **Keen Senses (2 XP):** +1 die on perception checks to spot danger or hidden details. *Passive.*
- **Trackless Step (2 XP):** Once/scene, leave no trail for the remainder of the scene. *Active.*
- **Urban Navigation (2 XP):** Never get lost in cities. *Passive.*
- **Silk Palms (2 XP):** When you bribe or gift a minor official, gain a temporary *String: Bought Silence*. Activate it to reduce DV by 1 on a Petition or Broker action involving that official (consumed). *Active.*
- **Camouflage (4 XP):** In natural terrain, spend an action to blend in; gain +2 dice to Stealth while remaining still, pursuers suffer −1 die to detect you. *Active, once/scene.*

Leader (Tactics, Morale, Coordination)

- **Command Presence (4 XP):** +1 die on leadership and intimidation rolls. *Passive.*
- **Network Weaver (4 XP):** Gain a minor contact in each new settlement you visit. *Passive.*
- **Inspire (3 XP):** As above.
- **Tactical Relay (3 XP):** Once/scene, spend 1 Boon; all allies currently acting in Near gain +1 Position on their next action. *Active.*

Monk (Unarmed Specialist)

- **Disciplined Body (3 XP):** +1 die to unarmed attacks; once/scene convert Harm 1→Fatigue; once/scene improve Position by one step. *Passive + active.*
- **Open Hand Technique (2 XP):** On a successful unarmed attack, choose one: knock target prone, push them back one band, or force them to drop a held item. *Active, once/scene.*
- **Iron Fist Way (6 XP):** +1 die to unarmed attacks; strikes count as enchanted for harming supernatural creatures. *Passive.*
- **Flowing Spirit Way (8 XP):** Convert 1 Harm per attack to Fatigue; +1 die against fear or charm effects. *Passive + active.*
- **Perfect Timing Way (7 XP):** Twice per scene, improve Position by +1; +1 die to reaction rolls. *Active.*

12.3 Equipment

12.3.1 Weapons by Weight Class

- **Light (4 XP):** Fast, concealable.
- **Medium (8 XP):** Balanced.
- **Heavy (12 XP):** Slow, powerful.

Melee Modifiers

Weight	Close	Near	Notes
Light	+2d	+1d	Quick
Medium	+1d	+2d	Set 1/scene or -1d first attack
Heavy	-1d	+3d	Set 1/scene or -2d first attack

Ranged & Tempo

Weight	Tempo	Close	Near	Far
Light	Fast	Controlled	+1d	—
Medium	Standard	Desperate	+2d	+1d
Heavy	Slow	Desperate	+1d	+3d

Tempo: Fast = Move+Shoot; Standard = Move or Shoot; Slow = Set/Brace, no Move+Shoot.

12.3.2 Armor Conversion

Armor	XP	Conversion	Penalty
Light	4	1 Harm→1 Fatigue	—
Medium	8	2 Harm→1 Fatigue	-1d physical
Heavy	12	3 Harm→2 Fatigue	-2d physical, no sprint

Conversion applies *per Harm instance* before marking Fatigue. Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.

12.3.3 Shields (Optional)

Shield	XP	Benefit	Tradeoff
Buckler	4	+1d Defend or +1 DV once	Off-hand
Heater	8	+1d Defend; 1 Harm→Fatigue	-1d Ranged
Pavise	12	Plant: heavy cover cone	Bulky, slow

Using a shield restricts weapon size to Light or Medium.

12.4 Equipment Condition & Upkeep

All gear can become **Neglected** or **Compromised**:

- **Neglected**: Weapons –1 die; Armor conversion worsened by 1 step.
- **Compromised**: Weapons –1 die first attack/round; Armor provides no conversion.

Repair:

- Short rest + tools: Remove Neglected.
- A scene of work or a smith: Remove Compromised.
- Enchanted items require the same repairs; enchantments are inactive while Compromised.

12.5 Magical Items (Enchantments)

Enchantments are permanent magical modifications treated as Talents (XP cost). They follow the same stacking rules: only one active enchantment per item unless noted. Enchanted items count as Assets for upkeep.

Sample Enchantments

- **Keen Edge (2 XP)**: +1 die vs armored targets.
- **Flaming Blade (4 XP)**: +1 fire damage, +1 Effect vs cold creatures.
- **Soulfire Weapon (6 XP)**: Ignores 1 point of armor/resistance.
- **Shadowweave Armor (2 XP)**: +1 die to Stealth while moving.
- **Runed Plate (4 XP)**: Reduce magical Backlash by 1 SB.
- **Boots of Sure Step (3 XP)**: Ignore difficult terrain.

Enchantment Limits

- Max enchantments = item's Tier (Light=1, Medium=2, Heavy=3).
- Identical benefits do not stack.
- Removing an enchantment: ritual (Wits+Arcana DV 4) + 1 XP per enchantment level.

12.6 Worked Example

*Sable earns 5 XP from a Drive and trades 2 Boons for 1 XP. She buys **Spellcraft** (6 XP). Later, she finds a **Keen Edge** longsword (2 XP enchantment) – she pays the XP and now has +1 die against armored foes.*

13 The Magic System

Magic in Fate's Edge is expressed through four interconnected paths. Each uses the same dice engine and SB/Obligation/Corruption economies.

Caster (Freeform):

Requires **Spellcraft (6 XP)**. Flexible, improvisational magic using elements and [TAGS]. Risk of Backlash.

Runekeeper (Rites):

Requires **Familiar (2 XP) + Codex (4 XP)**. Channel a Patron's Rites. Structured, powerful, debt-driven through **Obligation**.

Invoker (Symbols):

Requires one or more **Patron's Symbols (4 XP each)**. Ritual access to Patron Rites. Slow but safe; can *Crack the Seal* for instant cast at high cost.

Cantor (Songs):

Requires **Cantor's Path (8 XP) + Performance 2+, Lore 1+**. Sing Low Rites as Songs, trading Obligation for **Corruption**. Performance with transformative risk; corruption clock tied to **Spirit**.

13.1 Caster (Freeform / Weave & Cast)

Core Concept: Improvisational magic shaping raw elemental forces. Power brings instability.

Mechanics

- **Prerequisite:** Spellcraft (6 XP).
- **Process:** Two actions – **Weave** (shape) then **Cast** (release).
- **Roll:** Attribute (usually Wits or Spirit) + Arcana (or appropriate skill).
- **DV:** 1 + number of [TAGS]. Dangerous [TAGS] (Teleport, Transform, Dominate) add +2 each.
- **Backlash:** Every 1 on either roll generates SB. Total 1s determine severity (Minor/Moderate/Severe). The GM applies consequences tied to the elements used (see Elemental Backlash table).

Cantrips A spell with a single [TAG] can be cast as a Cantrip: one roll (standard action), no Weave phase. Cannot bypass wards or create large-scale effects.

13.2 Runekeeper (Rites)

Runekeepers bind structured magic through a Codex and a Thiasos (familiar spirit). They excel at reliable, thematic magic.

Requirements

- **Patron bond**
- **Thiasos (Familiar talent)**
- **Codex (4 XP)**

Invocation

- **1 Action** to invoke a Rite.
- Mark **Obligation** as listed.
- **Push It:** Mark +1 Obligation to increase duration or potency.

Patron's Gift (Free, requires Thiasos) Once per scene, imbue an item with +1 Melee and +1 Thematic Skill (matching Patron) for the scene. Push It to extend one more scene (+1 Obligation).

13.3 Invoker (Symbols)

Invokers channel power through consecrated Symbols. Rituals are slow but safe; *Crack the Seal* offers desperate speed.

Requirements

- A **Patron's Symbol** (4 XP each)

Ritual Invocation

- Takes DV+1 rounds.
- Always marks +1 Obligation.
- If Symbol is displayed (visible), DV -1 and Obligation -1 (min 0).

Crack the Seal

- Instant invocation (1 action).
- Mark +2 Obligation (+3 for High Rites).
- Symbol becomes COMPROMISED (repair in downtime or pay 1 XP).

Note: The Obligation cost cannot be reduced below 1.

Borrowed Grace (Invoker Talent) Once per scene, spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to gain +1 die on a combat action or +1 Effect on social/stealth action. Must display Symbol.

13.4 Cantor (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as Songs, channelling power through voice and performance. They do not incur Obligation; instead they track a **Corruption Clock** based on their **Spirit** – their willpower and connection to the intangible. A higher Spirit lets them resist the transformative pull of their songs longer, but when the clock fills, the change is more profound.

Requirements

- **Cantor's Path (8 XP).**
- Performance 2+, Lore 1+, Presence 2+.

Singing a Song

- **1 action** to begin; resolves at the start of your next turn.
- Roll **Lore + Performance** vs DV (typically 2–3).
- On success, the Low Rite effect occurs; no Obligation.
- Mark **Corruption accumulation** (see below).

Push It Resolve the Song immediately (instead of next turn). Mark **1 Fatigue** and advance your Corruption Clock by 1 segment.

Corruption Clock Your Corruption Clock has segments equal to your **Spirit** attribute. Mark a segment when you:

- Push a Song.
- Perform a **Resonant Rite** (a powerful thematic working designated by your Patron).
- The GM spends a Story Beat on your occult activities.

When the clock fills, you immediately gain a thematic **boon and burden** from the last Patron whose Rite you performed (see Patron corruption tables). Then reset the clock to zero (cannot go below your current Tier).

Chorus Cults (Optional)

If you perform a Resonant Rite before 10+ witnesses, you may found a **Chorus**. This grants a minor follower benefit (see Assets and Followers), but you must mark Obligation to the cult's patron (the patron whose Resonant Rite was sung to form the cult) each session you use it. **If neglected, the cult may fracture** – your followers could splinter into a rival sect, spread false rumours, or ally with a Patron's enemy. Keep an eye on your followers; a neglected Chorus can become a serious problem.

Inspire Chorus Once per scene, while actively singing a Song, all allies within Near range shift **Position +1** for one exchange (cannot exceed Controlled). Additional uses in the same scene mark toward Corruption accumulation.

Repertoire (Optional) Track a **Repertoire Clock [6]**. Mark a segment each time you learn a new unique Song. At 2 segments, reduce the base DV of all your Songs by 1 (min 2). At 4 segments, gain +1 die to Performance rolls. At 6 segments, you may learn one Standard Rite as a Song (temporary; requires practice to retain).

13.5 Sample Patrons and Rites (SRD Summary)

These examples provide Low and Standard Rites for common Patrons. GMs may expand.

Oath of Flame & Light **Domain:** Dawn, vows, radiant justice.

- **Rite of Kindle Vow (Low)** – Bind a scene-long vow; bearer gains +1 die when fulfilling it.
- **Rite of Lay on Hands (Low)** – Cleanse affliction, reduce Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue.
- **Rite of Radiant Smite (Standard)** – Next melee attack flares with light; +1 Harm, ignores undead armor.

The Sealed Gate **Domain:** Thresholds, wards, containment.

- **Rite of Sealed Threshold (Low)** – Mark a doorway; unauthorized crossing requires Resolve test.
- **Rite of Circle of Denial (Standard)** – Protective circle; spirits/outsideers resist to enter.
- **Rite of Banishment Knot (High)** – Cast out a supernatural entity; test vs its Cap.

Raéyn, Mistress of the Sea **Domain:** Tides, storms, sea journeys.

- **Rite of Tidemark's Blessing (Low)** – Steady footing on wet surfaces; +1 die to balance/climb.
- **Rite of Whispering Currents (Low)** – Learn safest route on water; +1 die to navigation.
- **Rite of Wave-Road Blessing (Standard)** – Consecrate a sea lane; +2 dice to travel or evasion.

Ikasha, She Who Sleeps **Domain:** Shadow, secrets, thresholds.

- **Touch the Umbral Veil (Low)** – +1 die to one Stealth roll; soften a noise.
- **Rite of Crossroads Raven (Low)** – Omen-raven gives +1 die to navigation or forces enemy hesitation.
- **Become the Shadow at the Crossroads (High)** – Intangible to mundane harm; pass through gaps; +2 dice Stealth.

Old Man of the Forest (Grimmir) **Domain:** Nature, seasons, wilderness.

- **Rite of the Speaking Seed (Low)** – Commune with local plants; +1 die to Survival/Investigation.
- **Rite of the Thornveil (Standard)** – Raise living barrier; allies gain +1 die to defense/stealth.
- **Rite of the World’s Wound (High)** – Heal blighted land; begin Ecosystem Restoration clock.

13.6 Elemental Backlash (Condensed)

When a free caster rolls 1s (or accepts SB to escalate), apply backlash themed to the dominant element. Severity: Minor (1 one), Moderate (2-3 ones), Severe (4+ ones). Players may accept +1 SB to escalate to the next tier.

1 X X			
Element Minor Backlash Major Backlash			
Earth / Fate	Slip, bind, encumbrance (–1 Position)	Fissure, entrapment (Clock +1 Collapse)	
Fire / Life	Smoke, sparks, heat (–1 Effect)	Blaze, fever (Clock +1 Fire or 1 Harm)	
Air / Luck	Scatter, misheard words (–1 Position)	Unlikely mishap (lose a tool or +1 SB)	
Water / Dreams	Slippery, slow (–1 Effect)	Undertow, veering path (Clock +1 Flood)	
Death / Obishaal	Whispers, chill (Shaken or Clock +1 Haunting)	Threshold opens (Clock +1 Crossing Due)	

13.7 Universal Rituals (Quick-Start)

These rituals are available to any character with ritual ability (Caster, Runekeeper, Invoker, or Cantor). Each lists Cast Time, Setup, Effect, and Costs.

1 c 1 1 X					
Ritual Tier Cast Time Setup / Components Effect / Cost					
Wayfinder’s Thread	Low	1 min	Red cord knotted thrice; whisper destination	Create tether to safe path.	
Cost: Fatigue if used >1/scene. Push: +1 SB reveals shortcut.					
Oath-Ward	Low	5 min	Chalk circle; sworn phrase	Ward small area vs intrusion.	Cost: Breaking oath triggers SB.
Ember-Glass	Low	1 min	Smoked glass	Sense heat sources through cover.	Cost: lose torch/tinder.
Salt-Cut	Low	1 min	Salt, bronze knife	Sever simple ongoing effect (rope, charm).	Cost: consume salt.
River’s Memory	Med	10 min	Bowl, personal token	Scry recent event tied to token, blurry.	Cost: token ruined.
Bargain-Bead	Med	10 min	Two carved beads	Invite spirit to parley.	Cost: give valuable concession or take SB.
Quiet Veil	Med	5 min	Ash, muffled bell	Muffle group sounds for scene.	Cost: Muted Condition.
Dream-Way Marker	Med	10 min	Inked sleep mask, water cadence	Mark safe entrance to Ways Between; short transit.	Cost: all Shaken on waking.
Purge	Med	10 min	Bitter herbs, clean blade	Cleanse taint/curse one step.	Cost: caster takes minor echo (–1 next action).
Summoner’s Gate	High	20 min	Circle, true-name sigil	Call known entity safely.	Cost: occupies concurrency slot; breaking terms creates SB.

13.8 TAGS System for Free Casting

Free casters build spells using [TAGS]. Each spell has a DV = 1 + number of TAGS (dangerous TAGS +2). Example: [Burning] [Area] [Force] = DV 4.

Common TAGS

- **Elemental:** Burning, Freezing, Storm, Stone, Wave, Wind.
- **Force:** Force, Area, Strike, Wall, Bind, Dispel.
- **Mind/Veil:** Veil, Scry, Memory, Command, Fear.
- **Life/Body:** HEAL, Purify, Strengthen, Waken, Beast.
- **Space/Motion (dangerous):** Leap, Fold, Gate, Gravity.
- **Creation (dangerous):** Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate.

DV Examples

- [Light] (Cantrip) – DV 2, one roll.
- [Burning] [Strike] – DV 3, two actions.
- [Fold] [Self] – DV 3 (Fold is dangerous +2, plus 1 tag = 3).

13.9 Paths of Magic Comparison

1111				
Path Core Risk Speed Flexibility				
Caster (Freeform)	Backlash	2 actions (1 for cantrip)	Very high	
Runekeeper (Rites)	Obligation	1 action	Moderate (Patron list)	
Invoker (Symbols)	Ritual time / Symbol damage	Slow (ritual) or instant (Crack)	Moderate (Symbols owned)	
Cantor (Songs)	Corruption (clock = Spirit)	1 action to begin, resolves next turn (Push for immediate)	Low	(Low Rites only)

14 Summoning

Summoning is the art of calling beings from beyond the mortal veil – spirits, elementals, the dead, fey, demons, or stranger entities. It is always dangerous, often costly, and never without consequence.

14.1 Who Can Summon?

Any character may attempt a summoning ritual, but only those with the **Pact-Whisperer** talent can reliably bind and command spirits in combat time. NPCs and plot events use the same principles: a summoner prepares a circle, pays a cost, and risks backlash.

14.2 Summoning for Narrative (Greater Powers)

Not all summonings are tactical. Sometimes the story demands calling a greater power – a patron-level entity, a forgotten god, or a primordial force. These rituals are not resolved with a single roll; they are extended challenges that drive the plot.

Ritual Structure for Greater Summonings

- **Preparation Clock [6–12]:** The summoner gathers rare components, secures a threshold, and learns the entity’s true name (or equivalent).
- **The Calling:** A dramatic scene where the summoner rolls **Spirit** + **Lore** vs. DV (set by the entity’s power). Failure may summon something *else*.
- **The Bargain:** Greater powers do not serve for free. They demand a price – a memory, a firstborn, a deed, or an ongoing Obligation (tracked as a campaign front).
- **Consequences:** On success, the entity manifests (briefly) and may grant a boon, answer a question, or perform a single impossible task. On failure, the entity corrupts, attacks, or curses the summoner.

Example: Summoning the Pale Shepherd’s Herald A village elder attempts to summon a death-herald to save a dying child. Preparation clock [8]: gather grave-ash, a silver bell, and the child’s true name. Calling roll: Spirit 2 + Lore 3 = 5 dice vs DV 5 → Partial. The herald appears but demands a year of the elder’s remaining life. The elder accepts; the child lives.

14.3 PC Summoner (Pact-Whisperer)

Player characters who specialize in summoning take the **Pact-Whisperer** talent (2 XP). This allows them to call and bind spirits for temporary aid in scenes.

Talents & Access

- **Lesser Pactwright** (2 XP): Call spirits of **Cap 1**.
- **Greater Pactwright** (4 XP): Call spirits of **Cap 3**.
- **Dual Pactwright** (6 XP): May maintain one spirit of each Cap simultaneously.

14.3.1 Core Mechanics – Call, Bind, and the Leash

Summoning a spirit follows three steps: **Call**, **Bind**, and **Leash** management.

1. **Call (1 Action):** The spirit manifests at Near range. Choose a spirit template (see sample templates below).
2. **Bind (1 Boon or 1 Fatigue):** Spend 1 Boon *or* mark 1 Fatigue to establish control. The spirit is now bound and will follow simple commands.

3. **Leash Capacity:** The spirit has a **Leash** – a track of segments equal to **Cap** + **Spirit** (Cap is the spirit's tier: 1 for Lesser, 3 for Greater). The Leash represents the strain of keeping the spirit in the mortal world.

Ticking the Leash The Leash ticks forward (gains segments) under the following conditions:

- The spirit takes Harm (1 segment per level of Harm).
- You command the spirit to act against its nature (1 segment).
- You **split focus** – take another significant action while the spirit is acting (1 segment).
- The spirit crosses a [WARD] without dispelling it (DV = Cap; tick segments equal to the ward's DV).
- (Optional narrative trigger) A rival contests control, or the spirit moves too far from you.

When the Leash Fills When the Leash reaches its capacity, the spirit acts **once according to its nature** (the GM decides the action, which is often destructive or self-serving), then departs immediately (or turns hostile at the GM's discretion). The bond is broken.

Boon Finesse Once per round, you may spend **1 Boon** to clear 1 tick from the current spirit's Leash (cannot be used after the Leash has already filled). This represents appeasing the spirit, reaffirming control, or offering a small token.

Commanding Spirits

- **Quick Command:** Simple orders ("attack that enemy", "move there", "defend me", "retrieve that object") do not consume your Action. You may issue one Quick Command per round as a free action.
- **Complex Command:** If the order requires interpretation, multiple steps, or finesse ("guard this door and alert me if anyone passes", "search the room for a hidden key"), it uses your Action for the turn.
- **Spirit Link (Major Talent – 10 XP):** Spirits act on your turn; all commands are free actions; reduce Leash ticking for natural behaviours by 1.

Spirit Bond Progression For spirits you summon regularly (e.g., a favoured elemental or a recurring shade), track a **Spirit Bond Clock [4]**.

- Mark segments for successful commands, shared victories, or mutual aid (once per type per session).
- At 2 segments: Gain +1 die to communicate with this spirit type.
- At 4 segments: The spirit becomes **Favored**. Choose one: Leash Capacity +1, *or* –1 tick per command (minimum 0). Additionally, the spirit grants you +1 Boon when it departs naturally (not destroyed or forced out).

14.3.2 Sample Spirit Templates

Lesser (Cap 1)

- **Shade:** Stealthy scout; can pass through cracks; Harm 1, Leash = 1+Spirit.
- **Emberling:** Small fire elemental; deals 1 Harm (fire) on touch; can ignite objects.
- **Tangle-root:** Plant spirit; can entangle one target (Entangled condition, Athletics DV 3 to break).

Greater (Cap 3)

- **Flame Elemental:** Area fire attack (Harm 2 to all in Close); immune to mundane fire; Leash = 3+Spirit.
- **Shadow Hound:** Track any scent; can move silently; attacks with Harm 2 (shadow bite).
- **Stone Guardian:** High defense; can interpose and reduce Harm to an ally by 1 (once per round). Harm 1, but +2 Armor.

Specializations (for recurring spirits) Choose one specialization when a spirit becomes Favored:

- **Combat Specialist:** +1 Harm on attacks; ignores first Harm 1 per scene.
- **Scout Form:** Stealthy; Cap 1 can carry 2 kg, Cap 3 can carry 10 kg; +2 dice to Stealth.
- **Utility Spirit:** Can perform simple tasks (opening unlocked doors, carrying light objects, fetching items).
- **Shield Guardian:** Once per round, interpose and convert an ally's Harm 1 into Fatigue on the spirit.

14.4 GM Guidelines for Summoning

NPC Summoners Treat enemy summoners as having the same limitations: they must Call (action) and Bind (Boon or Fatigue). Their spirits have a Leash clock. The GM may choose not to track Leash for minor NPCs if the fiction does not demand it, but for major antagonists, use the same mechanics – this creates tactical choices (e.g., attack the summoner to break control, or force the spirit to cross a ward).

Plot-Level Summonings When the story requires a massive summoning (a demon army, a dead god, the Hollow Bride), do not use PC mechanics. Instead:

- Create a **Ritual Clock [6–12]** that the party can disrupt.
- Each segment represents a component (blood sacrifice, alignment of stars, chanting cultists).
- The party can sabotage components, kill cultists, or break the circle to halt the summoning.
- If the clock fills, the entity arrives – now the party must bargain, fight, or flee.

Hazards of Greater Summoning

- **Uncontrolled Manifestation:** The entity may be hostile to everyone, including the summoner.
- **Collateral Damage:** Reality warps, wards fail, the dead rise, or the environment becomes a hazard.
- **Debt:** Even if bound, the entity extracts a price – an Obligation clock that ticks per scene, demanding sacrifice or service.

Example: The Cult of the Ninth Bell Cultists attempt to summon a fragment of the Ninth (void entity). A 6-segment clock: collect nine souls (segment 1), ring the forbidden bell (segment 2), etc. The party can interrupt at any segment. If the clock fills, the Ninth Rim appears – treat as a Tier IV hazard with a Bargain (offer a memory) or a Catastrophe (reality starts erasing the town).

14.5 Summoning Talents (PC) Summary

- **Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)** – base access.
- **Lesser Pactwright (2 XP)** – Call Cap 1 spirits.
- **Greater Pactwright (4 XP)** – Call Cap 3 spirits.
- **Spirit Synergy (4 XP)** – When maintaining two spirits simultaneously, reduce each Spirit's Leash ticking by 1 (min 1).
- **Bonded Summoner (3 XP)** – Favored spirits (Spirit Bond Clock completed) gain an additional –1 tick per command (stacks with other reductions).
- **Spirit Link (10 XP)** – Commands are free actions; spirits act on your turn; reduce Leash ticking for natural behaviours by 1.
- **True Name Keeper (15 XP)** – Call any previously met spirit by its true name; reduce Leash Capacity by 2 (min equal to Spirit) for that summoning.
- **Legion Master (18 XP)** – You may maintain a number of spirits simultaneously equal to your **Presence** (minimum 2). Each spirit is tracked separately.

15 Complications

All actions in Fate's Edge carry risk. Complications are the narrative, mechanical, and environmental consequences that arise from failure, pressure, or the GM spending Story Beats.

15.1 Story Beats (SB)

Story Beats are the GM's primary currency for introducing complications. Each die result of **1** generates 1 SB. Re-rolling a 1 does not erase its SB; if the re-rolled die also shows 1, it generates additional SB.

Spending SB The GM spends SB to introduce complications. Use the following menu as a guideline:

- **1 SB:** Minor pressure – noise, trace, tick a 4/6 clock +1, worsen Position by one step.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback – alarm raised, lose cover/advantage, a lesser foe appears, split the party briefly.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble – reinforcements arrive, key gear breaks (temporarily), a major twist shifts the scene.
- **4+ SB:** Scene-shaping turn – a trap springs, authority arrives, the environment changes dramatically, a Patron manifests an omen.

Limits on SB per Scene

- Base SB budget: 4 + highest character Tier (e.g., Tier I = 5, Tier III = 7).
- Maximum 12 SB for standard scenes, 16 SB for climactic scenes.
- Unspent SB may carry over between scenes (GM discretion, max 4).

GM as Player: Lean Into Surprise The SB rules are guidelines, not straitjackets. The GM is free to spend SB in any way that serves the story. However, the game is **optimized** to follow the SB economy: each 1 on the dice is an invitation for the GM to play, too. *Spend SB to surprise yourself.* When you introduce a complication, do not simply punish — change the situation in a way that you didn't foresee. A well-spent SB should make you grin as much as it makes the players groan. *You are not a referee; you are a co-author of chaos.*

15.2 Boons

Boons are the players' resource for mitigating complications or turning the tide.

Earning Boons

- **Miss (0 successes):** Gain 2 Boons (provided the roll was meaningful and SB was generated).
- **Partial (0 < successes < DV):** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Bond-driven action:** Once per bond per session, when you act in a way that meaningfully engages a bond and you provide an Intricate Description, gain 1 Boon.
- **GM award:** For creative solutions, sacrifices, or outstanding roleplay.

Spending Boons

- Re-roll a single die in any pool (after seeing the result).
- Activate an on-screen Asset (1 Boon).
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.

- Power certain Rites or abilities.
- Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once per session, during downtime; max 2 XP per session).

Limits on Boons

- Hold up to 5 Boons. At scene end, reduce to 2 (excess lost).
- Max 2 Boons earned from failures per character per scene.

15.3 Clocks as Complications

Clocks track accumulating threats or progress. They are a visible way to manage pressure.

When to Use a Clock

- **Threat Clock (4–8 segments):** Fills with enemy action, environmental decay, or social collapse. When full, a defined disaster occurs.
- **Progress Clock (4–8 segments):** Fills with player successes to achieve a goal (e.g., escape, research, negotiation).
- **Contest Clocks:** Two clocks race – first to fill wins.

Ticking Clocks

Clocks advance when:

- The GM spends SB (e.g., 1 SB = tick a relevant clock +1).
- A failed roll directly relates to the threat (GM discretion).
- A scene transition or scripted event occurs.

Example Clocks

- **Guards Incoming [6]** – ticks on noise or missed stealth. On fill, a patrol arrives.
- **Collapsing Bridge [4]** – ticks on failed Athletics or heavy impacts. On fill, bridge falls.
- **Patron’s Patience [8]** – ticks each time Obligation is ignored. On fill, Patron demands service.

15.4 Hazards (Environmental, Social, Magical)

Hazards are ongoing complications that require action to avoid or mitigate.

Environmental Hazards

- **Active:** Fire spreading, flooding, toxic gas – represented by a Threat Clock that ticks each round or on SB spends.

- **Passive:** Difficult terrain, darkness, extreme heat/cold – impose Position penalties or DV modifiers.

Social Hazards

- **Rumors:** A clock that advances when the party fails social rolls; when full, a faction turns hostile.
- **Scrutiny:** Worsens Position for stealth or deception.
- **Reputation Damage:** Future social rolls start at worse Position.

Magical Hazards

- **Backlash Zone:** An area where free casting automatically generates +1 SB per spell.
- **Ward / Seal:** Requires a roll to pass; failure triggers a consequence (harm, alarm, etc.).
- **Leaking Veil:** Spirits or fey occasionally manifest spontaneously (GM spends SB to introduce).

15.5 Fear Effects

When a character escalates on the Fear Track (Shaken → Frightened → Panicked), roll or choose an effect from the table below. Apply to NPCs by default; PCs may adopt as narrative guidance.

>r 11	
d10	Effect – Magic Tags
1	Freeze: Cannot act this round, staring or trembling. Silence, Stasis
2	Flee: Must move at full speed away from the source of Fear. Movement, Wind
3	Drop: Drops what they are holding. Disarm, Break
4	Beg: Pleads or bargains incoherently. Compulsion, Voice
5	Hide: Seeks cover, concealment, or allies. Shadow, Illusion
6	Attack in Panic: Lashes out wildly at the nearest target. Rage, Fire
7	Blunder: Stumbles into danger (trap, hazard, off balance). Chaos, Trickery
8	Obey: Instinctively follows a simple command from the fear-causer. Command, Charm
9	Break Down: Sobs, prays, or becomes useless until aided. Curse, Despair
10	Catatonia: Becomes unresponsive, requiring intervention. Sleep, Dream

Fear Track Escalation

- **Shaken:** Apply minor effects (hesitation, –1 die, startled).
- **Frightened:** Roll normally on the table.
- **Panicked:** Apply severe or exaggerated results (e.g., 2 = reckless flight into danger, 6 = attacks allies).

15.6 The Deck of Consequences (Optional)

The **Deck of Consequences** is a narrative tool that turns Story Beats into thematic, unpredictable complications. It replaces or supplements GM fiat with randomized twists that keep the GM as surprised as the players. Using the deck is entirely optional, but it excels at generating memorable setbacks without slowing the game.

Deck Structure Use a standard 52-card deck (jokers optional). Suits map to complication themes:

Suit	Theme	Examples
Hearts	Social / Emotional	Betrayal, scandal, broken trust, awkward moment
Spades	Physical / Harm	Bruise, injury, collapse, gear damage
Clubs	Material / Cost	Resource loss, gear failure, debt, ruined supplies
Diamonds	Magical / Spiritual	Omen, curse, Patron attention, reality bend

Rank Severity

- **2–5:** Minor inconvenience (noise, Fatigue 1, small delay).
- **6–10:** Moderate setback (alarm raised, gear broken, Position worsened).
- **J, Q, K:** Major consequence (reinforcements, key gear destroyed, front clock advanced).
- **A:** Severe twist (trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts).

When to Draw The GM may draw from the deck when:

- A roll shows two or more 1s.
- The GM spends 2+ Story Beats at once.
- A major clock fills (scene or campaign clock).
- During travel to generate an unexpected encounter.

Aim for 1–2 draws per session; more if the tone skews chaotic.

Procedure

1. Note the number of SB spent (or generated).
2. Draw a number of cards equal to the SB spent (minimum 1, maximum 3).
3. Synthesise a single narrative complication from the combination of suits and the highest rank.
4. Do not reshuffle until the deck runs out or the session ends – this creates a natural “fate budget.”

Synthesising Complications Combine the suits and the highest rank into one fiction-first twist. Examples:

- **Hearts + Spades:** Emotional betrayal that leads to physical harm ("Your ally flees, and the portcullis drops between you.").
- **Clubs + Diamonds:** Resource drain with magical backlash ("The ritual consumes your healing herbs and leaves a scar on the threshold.").
- **All four suits:** A crowd riots, loots your supplies, and a spirit feeds on the chaos.

Shortcut Table For fast interpretation at the table:

Suit	Low (2–5)	High (J–A)
Hearts	Awkward social moment	Betrayal, scandal, broken trust
Spades	Bruise, small stumble	Serious injury, structural collapse
Clubs	Minor loss (rations, coins)	Major asset destroyed, debt called
Diamonds	Omen, eerie noise	Patron demand, reality bends

GM as Player: Embrace the Twist The Deck of Consequences is not a punishment machine. It is a tool for the GM to *play* – to be surprised, to discover the shape of the complication alongside the players. When you draw a card, resist the urge to soften it. Let the fiction guide you, and trust that a well-placed twist makes the story better. *You are not the enemy; you are the chaos collaborator.*

15.7 Integrating Complications with SB and Boons

- SB and Boons create a push-pull: SB gives the GM tools to escalate; Boons give players tools to recover or resist.
- A well-spent SB should change the situation, not just punish. Offer the player a Devil's Bargain: "I'll spend 2 SB to have the guard turn around – but you'll owe a favor."
- Clocks make threat visible; when a clock ticks, describe what changes in the fiction.

15.8 Example: Complication in Action

Lyra misses a stealth roll (0 successes) while sneaking past a guard post. She gains 2 Boons. The GM spends 1 SB: "Your foot scrapes a loose stone – the guard looks up." (Tick Guards Alert [4] +1). Later, the GM spends another 2 SB: "The guard calls for backup – two more arrive. New clock: Reinforcements [6]." Lyra uses 1 Boon to re-roll a failed athletics test to climb a wall, escaping just as the clock reaches 4.

Another scene: Lyra rolls three 1s on a critical casting. The GM draws three cards from the Deck of Consequences: Knave of Hearts, 7 of Clubs, Ace of Spades. Synthesis: "You slip past the first guard, but your cloak catches on a rusty nail (resource drain). Worse, the second guard recognises your face from a wanted poster – she's your cousin (social betrayal). She hesitates, then shouts 'Traitor!' As she draws her blade, a hidden portcullis drops behind you (scene shift). You're trapped in the courtyard." The GM grins – they didn't plan any of that.

16 Coordination Rules & Strategies

16.1 Purpose

Coordination turns individual actions into decisive outcomes. This section defines how allies combine moves, share resources, and sequence actions to overcome threats without slowing play.

16.2 Core Principles

- **Fiction First.** Describe how you help. Mechanics follow the fiction.
- **Clear Stakes.** State Position $\rightarrow$ DV, what help changes, and what risk the helper accepts.
- **One Spotlight at a Time.** Resolve one acting character's roll; fold assistance into that action.
- **Visible Costs.** Story Beats (SB), Obligation, Fatigue, and asset states are tracked openly.

16.3 Shared Vocabulary

Acting Character

The PC whose roll resolves the team's immediate goal.

Assistant

A PC who contributes fictionally; they do not roll unless the move calls for it.

Exchange

A short beat of simultaneous activity (often 1 round of table time).

Range Bands

Close, Near, Far – coordination options often require allies to be *Near*.

16.4 Assistance (Baseline)

- **Declare Help.** An assistant states a concrete contribution (tool, opening, lure, cover).
- **Benefit.** Acting character gains **+1d** (up to the table's assist cap). The GM may instead allow **+1 Position** or **+1 Effect** if the fiction fits.
- **Limits.** One assistant per PC per exchange by default; followers can assist per their stat block.
- **Cost.** The assistant accepts any oncoming risk named by the GM (SB, Fatigue, collateral).

16.5 Position $\rightarrow$ DV

The GM sets Position from fiction; Position maps to DV for the acting roll (typical ladder):

- **Dominant** $\Rightarrow$ **DV 2** (time, tools, clear access)

- **Controlled** ⇒ **DV 3** (pressure, partial access)
- **Desperate** ⇒ **DV 4–5+** (hostile field, countdown)

16.6 Bonds & Boon Sharing

Bonds signal trusted ties; Boons are the table's spotlight currency.

- **Base Gifting.** Any PC may gift **1 Boon per scene** to an ally with a brief narrative justification.
- **Bonded Allies.** If characters share a bond, they may gift **2 Boons per scene**.
- **Assistance via Boons.** A gifted Boon may be spent immediately to assist the ally's roll (counts as the assistant's contribution for that action).
- **Tracking.** Record shared Boons openly to avoid double-counting. The GM may require a short story beat for each gift.

16.7 Stacking Limits

To prevent "one true combo," a PC may benefit from at most **two cooperative effects** on the same action (choose which apply). *Inspire*, *Tactical Relay*, and similar talents each count as one.

16.8 Timing & Sequencing

- **Declare Order.** The GM frames the exchange; players state intent in any order; resolve the acting roll, then apply assists/Boons that were declared for it.
- **Ready/Overwatch.** Players may hold an action with a clear trigger; if triggered, resolve before the next exchange starts.
- **Refresh Windows.** "Once/scene" effects reset at scene end; "once/exchange" refresh at the next beat.

16.9 Followers in Coordination

A follower may assist for up to **+3d** (or **+4d** with *Exceptional Coordination+*). They cannot receive PC-only benefits (e.g., *Inspire*) unless a talent states otherwise.

16.10 Cooperative Talents (Options)

Inspire (3 XP) Once/scene, spend 1 Boon and provide a brief narrative justification. Choose one:

- **Bonded Ally (Near):** That ally gains **+1 Boon** and **+1d** on their next roll.
- **Self:** You gain **+1d** on your next roll.
- **Rally (Near Allies):** Each other PC in **Near** gains **+1d** on their next roll.

- **Tactical Coordination (Near Allies):** All allies currently acting gain **+1 Position** on their next action.

Limits: Followers cannot benefit. Each PC can benefit from *Inspire* at most once per scene. Requires *Near* unless targeting *Self*. Counts toward stacking limit.

Tactical Relay (3 XP) Once/scene, spend 1 Boon: all allies currently acting in **Near** gain **+1 Position** on their next action. Followers excluded.

Shield Wall (4 XP) If you and at least one ally each wield a shield and are adjacent: as a *Defend* action, grant **+1d Defend** to all in the Wall and convert the first incoming Harm (any one) to Fatigue. Ends if formation breaks.

Spotter's Mark (3 XP) *Aim* a target (1 action). Until end of scene or until target breaks line of sight, each **PC in Near** may claim **+1d** or **+1 Effect** once vs. that target. Once/scene you may spend 1 Boon to refresh the mark.

Battle Cant (2 XP) Once/scene, establish silent signals. On the next coordinated action where at least two PCs act on the same beat, those PCs gain **+1 Position**. Spend 1 Boon to include a third PC.

Medic's Hand (3 XP) When you *Stabilize* an ally mid-scene, also **clear 1 Fatigue** or **downgrade Harm 2→1**. Spend 1 Boon to do both. Not usable in Downtime healing.

Anchor Sigil (Runekeeper, 4 XP) Bank 1 Boon on a prepared sigil. Once this scene, when an ally *Casts* or *Invokes a Rite*, discharge: **-1 DV** for that action *or* redirect minor backlash to you as **Fatigue +1**.

Exceptional Coordination+ (8 XP) Your follower assist cap increases to **+4d**. If **Bonded** with that follower, you may split as **+2d** to two different allies on the same exchange.

16.11 GM Guidance (One Page)

- **Ask for the Beat.** Require one sentence of how help changes the fiction.
- **Name the Risk.** Before rolling, say what the helper risks (SB, collateral, position flip).
- **Favor Position Shifts.** When in doubt, let excellent help improve Position rather than stack dice.
- **Spread the Love.** Rotate who can meaningfully help each exchange; spotlight bonds and distinct roles.

Micro-Example: Assisting a Lockpick

Lyra (Wits 3 + Tinker 2) picks a lock (Controlled, DV 3). Thane helps by shielding her with his shield (assist, +1d). Lyra rolls 5 dice: 9,6,4,2,1 → 2 successes vs DV 3 → Partial. She gains 1 Boon. The GM spends the 1 SB (from the 1): "The lock clicks open, but Thane's movement draws a guard's attention. Tick Guards Alert [4] +1."

16.12 Optional Rule: Multi-Character Followers

Overview

A player may control multiple characters by linking them as mutual Followers. This option also covers absent players' characters when consent is given.

Core Mechanics

- **Cap Tier +1:** A Follower may advance up to one Tier higher than their leader's current Tier.
- **Multi-Character Play:** A player may designate two PCs as Followers of each other. Only one is the *active* PC at a time; the other functions as a Follower.
- **Absent PCs:** With consent, an absent player's PC may be run as a temporary Follower at Cap Tier +1.

Switching Active Characters

- **Switch Cost:** When switching, the previously active PC immediately becomes a Follower of the new active PC at Cap Tier +1.
- **Condition Gate:** A PC cannot be switched *to* if Compromised, Seized, or otherwise narratively unfit for active duty.
- **Narrative Justification:** The fiction must support the switch (returning from a journey, recovering from harm, taking point for a specific task).
- **Strategic Choice:** Switching trades autonomy for support – gaining a powerful Follower but losing a full PC.

Balance Notes

- Prevents abuse by making switching itself the cost.
- Maintains narrative logic – leadership shifts naturally reshape party structure.
- Creates strategic depth – switching is a meaningful tactical decision.
- Keeps all characters relevant, encouraging upkeep even when not active.

Coordination Quick Reference

- **Assist:** +1d (or +1 Position/Effect). Cost: assistant accepts risk.
- **Boon Gift:** 1 Boon/scene (2 if Bonded). Requires justification.
- **Stacking Limit:** Max 2 cooperative effects per action.
- **Position** → **DV:** Dominant=2, Controlled=3, Desperate=4–5.

17 Rituals, Rites, and Invocations

Magic in Fate's Edge is not limited to the gifted. Anyone with knowledge, time, and the right components can perform a **ritual** – a slow, careful working that calls upon a Patron, a spirit, or the hidden grammar of the world.

17.1 Rituals (Universal)

A ritual is a magical working that takes **Significant Time** (hours) or **Days**, requires specific **components** (rare herbs, a consecrated circle, a true name), and always carries risk.

Who Can Attempt a Ritual? Any character, regardless of magical talent. They need:

- A clear **intent** (what they want to achieve).
- A **method** (e.g., summoning circle, prayer, sympathetic object).
- **Components** (consumed or used up).
- **Time** (at least one scene of uninterrupted work).

Ritual Resolution The GM sets a **DV** (typically 4–6) based on the scope of the effect, and the player rolls **Spirit** + **Lore** (or another appropriate skill). On a success, the ritual works as intended. On a **Partial**, it works but with a cost (backlash, extra time, compromised component). On a **Miss**, it fails, and the GM may introduce a complication (e.g., the summoned entity is hostile, the ward collapses).

Ritual Costs

- **Obligation:** If the ritual invokes a Patron, mark +1 Obligation (or more for greater powers).
- **Components:** Rare or precious components may be consumed.
- **SB:** The GM gains SB equal to the number of 1s rolled, as usual.
- **Backlash:** On a Partial or Miss, the GM may impose a thematic backlash (e.g., the wrong spirit answers, a ward backfires).

Example Rituals See the “Universal Rituals” table in the Magic System section for examples: *Wayfinder’s Thread*, *Oath-Ward*, *Bargain-Bead*, etc.

17.2 Learned Rites (Runekeepers)

Characters who bind themselves to a **single Patron** and study that Patron’s **Codex** become **Runekeepers**. Their magic is structured, immediate, and tied to service.

- **One-Patron Rule.** A Runekeeper may be bound to only one Patron at a time.
- **Thiasos (Familiar).** Requires a Thiasos (Familiar talent) to access the Patron’s Gift (see below).
- **Codex (4 XP).** Grants access to the Patron’s Rites.
- **Invoke Rites.** Invoke a known Rite as a **1 action** effect. Mark **+1 Obligation** (or as listed). *Push It:* +1 additional Obligation to amplify the effect.

17.2.1 Rites Difficulty Value (DV)

$$DV = \max(\text{Obligation Cost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Tier})$$

Obligation Cost is the Rite’s listed toll; Spirit reduces it; Tier sets the minimum.

17.3 Invokers and Symbols

Invokers relate to Patrons through consecrated **Symbols** – physical tokens (4 XP each). They may own Symbols of different Patrons (one per Patron).

- **Ritual Invocation.** Display the Symbol and perform the Rite as a ritual (DV+1 rounds). Completion marks **+1 Obligation**.
- **Crack the Seal.** Resolve instantly by marking **+2 Obligation** (+3 for High Rites) and setting the Symbol to COMPROMISED. The Symbol is inert until restored (Downtime action + test DV 3, or spend 1 XP).
- **Display Requirement.** Symbols must be openly visible to function in a ritual.

17.4 Obligation Capacity and Clearing

A character’s **Obligation Capacity** = Spirit + Presence. Track total Obligation across all Patrons (or Symbols).

- **Exceeding Capacity:** Mark 1 Fatigue per segment over capacity. Cannot invoke Rites or perform rituals until Obligation is reduced below Capacity.
- **Clearing Obligation (Off-Screen).** Perform an act of service aligned with the Patron and provide an Intricate Description. Clear 1 segment per act.
- **Clearing Obligation (On-Screen).** With the *Focused Devotion* talent (3–5 XP), once per scene spend 1 Boon to clear 1 segment (cannot clear segments accrued in the same scene).

17.5 Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Any character with a **Thiasos (Familiar)** may invoke their Patron's Gift. Requires 1 Boon, 1 action, once per scene. Touch an item; until scene end it grants **+1 Melee** and **+1 Thematic Skill** (see table below). *Push It*: extend one more scene by marking +1 Obligation.

@p3.8cmp3.8cmp7.5cm@

~~Patron~~ **+1 Thematic Skill Gift / Lore Bestowal**

Ikasha (Shadow, Penumbra)	Stealth	Grants the hush between footsteps and the raven's omen at every threshold.
Mykkiel (Judgment, Writ)	Command	Grants the authority of seal and sentence, words that bind like iron.
The Witness (Truth, Revelation)	Notice	Grants the unblinking gaze that unmaskers deceit and remembers every oath.
Sealed Gate (Boundaries, Closure)	Tinker	Grants mastery of thresholds—doors that yield or bar at your command.
Raéyn (Storm, Tides)	Skirmish	Grants the sailor's fortune: winds that shift, storms that answer to will.
Khemesh (Abyss, Pressure)	Skirmish	Grants the crushing silence of the deep, where strength is drowned in weight.
Mab (Glamour, Courts)	Persuade	Grants the mask of favor, a voice that bends courtiers and kindles desire.
Sacred Geometry (Perfect Forms)	Tinker	Grants the compass of perfection, every shape reduced to its true measure.
Clockwork Monad (Mechanism, Process)	Tinker	Grants the certainty of repetition: a cycle that never falters, a gear that never slips.
Varnek Karn (Ossuary, Dominion of the Dead)	Command	Grants the silence of the archive, where the dead obey and records speak.
Nidhoggr (Deep Earth, Rot)	Skirmish	Grants the weight of ages, the strength of stone and the hunger of roots.
The Traveler (Ways, Roads)	Notice	Grants the open way, a compass that never rests, and roads where none are marked.
Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn, Vows)	Command	Grants the fire of dawn, a vow that shields the faithful and sears the faithless.
Carrion King (Carrion, Renewal)	Survival	Grants the feast of decay, where what is dead becomes seed for what lives.
Gallows Bell (Doom, Last Rites)	Command	Grants the toll of ending, a voice that closes stories and calls debts due.
Old Man of the Forest (Primal Humanity, Instinct)	Survival	Grants the wild memory: fang, fire, and the path of instinct through the dark wood.
Isoka (Serpents, Shedding)	Skirmish	Grants the serpent's coil, strength in sudden strike and wisdom in renewal.
Inaea (Mercy, Hearth)	Persuade	Grants the hearth's warmth, shelter to the weary and mercy for the lost.
Maelstraeus (Infernal Bargainer)	Persuade	Grants the contract's weight, every deal sealed in fire and shadow.
Livaea (Temptation, Desire)	Persuade	Grants the lure of longing, beauty sharpened into power

over hearts.
 Malachai (Curses, Corruption) Command Grants cursed blessings—boons that shine bright yet
 seed hunger.
 Patron's Gift: Thematic Skill and lore.

17.6 Borrowed Grace (Invoker Talent)

Once per scene, spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue (1 action) to gain **+1 die** to a single combat action, or **+1 Effect** to a social/stealth action. Requires visibly displaying your Patron's Symbol. If the Symbol is Compromised, Borrowed Grace works at **-1 die**.

17.7 Mixing Paths

Characters may combine Rituals, Rites, Invocations, and Summoning. However, specialization is usually stronger; mixing increases upkeep (Obligation, Symbol state, Leash, component tracking) without guaranteed power gains. Let fiction guide choices.

18 Tags & Effects Library

Tags are keywords that define the mechanical and narrative behavior of spells, rites, talents, and assets. They do nothing on their own; they only function when granted by a rule (Spell, Rite, Talent, Ability). Unless noted otherwise, the **Duration** of a tag effect is **Scene**, and the **DV** for contests or resistances is **set by the fiction** (typical range 2–5).

18.1 The Eight Elements

Every spell or magical effect is built from one or more of the eight fundamental elements. The first four are physical; the second four are metaphysical.

Element	Domain	Typical Backlash
Air	Movement, sound, wind, speed	Scatter, vertigo, deafening gusts
Fire	Energy, destruction, light, passion	Burns, smoke, uncontrolled blaze
Earth	Solidity, stone, metal, endurance	Rubble, heavy footing, tremors
Water	Fluidity, healing, cold, emotion	Flood, slippery ground, dampness
Fortune	Chance, luck, unpredictability	Random mishap, fragile success
Life	Vitality, growth, healing, nature	Overgrowth, fever, parasitic plants
Fate	Destiny, inevitability, causality	Options close, fixed outcome
Death/Dreams (Obishaal)	Endings, sleep, thresholds, memory	Whispers, numbness, threshold shifts

18.2 Effect Tags

Effect tags describe what the magic *does*. They are combined with element tags to form spells.

Common Effect Tags:

- | | |
|-------------|---------------------|
| • [AREA] | • [HEAL] |
| • [BANISH] | • [MARK] |
| • [BARRIER] | • [OATH] |
| • [BIND] | • [PASSAGE] |
| • [CLEANSE] | • [REVEAL] |
| • [COMMAND] | • [SANCTIFY] |
| • [CONJURE] | • [SEAL] / [UNSEAL] |
| • [COUNTER] | • [STRIKE] |
| • [CURSE] | • [TRANSPORT] |
| • [DEFEND] | • [VEIL] |
| • [DISPEL] | • [WARD] |
| • [FORTIFY] | |

18.3 How to Build a Spell

A spell is a combination of **one or more element tags** and **one or more effect tags**. The base Difficulty Value is:

$$DV = 1 + \text{total number of tags (element + effect)}$$

Dangerous Tags. Some effects are so powerful that each dangerous tag adds **+2 DV** instead of +1. Dangerous tags include: [GATE], [FOLD], [LEAP], [CREATE], [SUMMON], [TRANSMUTE], [ANIMATE], [TRANSFORM], [DOMINATE], [REWIND].

Stacking Identical Effect Tags. You may include the same effect tag multiple times to increase its potency. Each additional copy adds its normal DV cost. For example:

- [AIR] [DEFEND] – 2 tags → DV 3. Grants +1 die to one defense roll.
- [AIR] [DEFEND] [DEFEND] – 3 tags → DV 4. Grants +2 dice to one defense roll.

Stacking is limited by the caster's Tier (max 3 copies per effect at Tier III, 4 at Tier V).

18.4 Example Spells

Light (Cantrip) [FIRE] [ILLUMINATE] – 2 tags → DV 3. One roll. Creates a small, sustained light.

Shield of Air [AIR] [DEFEND] – 2 tags → DV 3. One action. Grants +1 die to next defense roll.

Double Shield [AIR] [DEFEND] [DEFEND] – 3 tags → DV 4. One action. Grants +2 dice to next defense roll.

Flame Cloak [FIRE] [AREA] [DEFEND] – 3 tags → DV 4. Two actions. Enemies suffer –1 die to approach; caster gains +1 die to defend against fire.

Healing Touch [LIFE] [HEAL] – 2 tags → DV 3. One action. Removes 1 Fatigue from touched ally.

Mend Wound [LIFE] [HEAL] [HEAL] – 3 tags → DV 4. One action (or scene, GM discretion). Removes 2 Fatigue, or downgrades Harm 1→0.

Teleport (Self) [AIR] [FOLD] – [FOLD] is dangerous (+2 instead of +1). Total DV = 1 + 1 (for [AIR]) + 2 (for [FOLD]) = 4. Teleport self within Near range.

18.5 Control & Countermagic

[DISPEL] – End an ongoing magical effect or construct.

- **DV:** By fiction (usually equal to the effect's Tier or casting DV).
- **Hit:** Effect ends or is suppressed per source text.
- **Partial:** Effect suppressed briefly (one exchange) or reduced in scope.
- **Miss:** No effect; GM may gain SB.

[COUNTER] – Interrupt a spell, rite, or ritual in progress.

- **Timing:** During the casting window (declared action or ritual phase).
- **DV:** By fiction (complexity of the interrupted effect).
- **Hit:** Cancel the action; resources used are lost.
- **Partial:** Worsen the caster's Position or impose Fatigue.
- **Miss:** No interruption; GM may spend SB to escalate.

[BARRIER] – Create cover, obstruction, or a physical wall.

- **DV:** By fiction (size, material, duration).
- **Hit:** Place a barrier with Integrity Clock [2/4/6]; it blocks movement/attacks until cracked.
- **Partial:** Barrier is fragile or has a gap.
- **Countered by:** [DISPEL], brute force (Athletics), or clever route.

[SEAL] / [UNSEAL] – Lock or unlock a container, door, or portal (not spirits).

- **DV:** By fiction (quality of lock, magical binding).
- **Hit:** Locked/unlocked as intended; specify any bypass conditions.
- **Partial:** Seal is temporary or leaks (can be forced open with +1 DV).

18.6 Concealment & Revelation

[VEIL] – Obscure a person, object, or zone.

- **DV:** By fiction (scale, conditions).
- **Hit:** Impose –1 die to Notice or perception rolls against the veiled subject; specify limits (angle, distance, scent).
- **Partial:** Works only at a limited range or in dim light.
- **Countered by:** [REVEAL], strong light, physical proof.

[REVEAL] – Expose illusions, disguises, or hidden clauses.

- **DV:** By fiction (complexity of the concealment).
- **Hit:** Surface the truth; describe how the revelation manifests (brief glow, visible flaw, etc.).
- **Partial:** A tell or clue, not the full picture.

[MARK] – Tag a target for tracking or leverage.

- **DV:** By fiction (resistance, visibility).
- **Hit:** Place a visible or invisible mark; once per scene, you or an ally gain +1 die when acting directly against the Marked target.
- **Partial:** Mark is noisy or short-lived.
- **Countered by:** [CLEANSE], [DISPEL], or listed materials (salt, iron).

18.7 Boons & Burdens

[CURSE] – Inflict a sticky hindrance with a clear release condition.

- **DV:** By fiction (severity, target's resilience).
- **Hit:** Apply a named Condition (e.g., SHAKEN, WEAKENED) that persists until the release condition is met.
- **Partial:** Condition is milder or intermittent.
- **Countered by:** [CLEANSE] or the listed key (apology, theft return, pilgrimage).

[CLEANSE] – Remove or suppress a Condition (poison, disease, curse, fear).

- **DV:** By fiction (potency of the affliction).
- **Hit:** Remove one named Condition.
- **Partial:** Suppress or reduce severity for the scene.

[FORTIFY] – Harden a person, place, or object against a specific vector (fire, blades, fear, persuasion).

- **DV:** By fiction (scale, strength).
- **Hit:** Raise Position by one step or reduce consequence severity for attacks of that vector this scene.
- **Partial:** Limited scope (one ally, one doorway).

18.8 Influence & Oaths

[COMMAND] – Issue a clear order to a sapient target.

- **DV:** By fiction (authority, leverage, fear, ritual standing).
- **Hit:** Target complies now or suffers an immediate cost stated by the GM.
- **Partial:** Target hesitates, bargains, or partially complies.
- **Miss:** Refusal or blowback (GM may spend SB).

[OATH] – Bind parties to terms; breaking has teeth.

- **DV:** By fiction (witnesses, sanctity, stakes).
- **Hit:** Enforceable pact with stated boon for keeping and consequence for breaking.
- **Partial:** A loophole exists in the oath.
- **Countered by:** Release clause, [CLEANSE] if text allows.

[SANCTIFY] – Consecrate a zone to a code or Patron.

- **DV:** By fiction (size, opposition).

- **Hit:** Specify allowed/prohibited acts; violations start at Controlled Position or impose a soft consequence.
- **Partial:** Patchy coverage (e.g., only the altar, not the whole room).
- **Countered by:** Opposing rite, profanation (bloodshed, lies), time.

18.9 Movement & Making

[PASSAGE] – Declare a route as permitted or easy.

- **DV:** By fiction (length, danger).
- **Hit:** Allies on that path gain improved flow (+1 Position or ignore one level of difficult terrain).
- **Partial:** Only one ally or one segment benefits.

[TRANSPORT] – Move a target across an obstacle (blink, lift, pull).

- **DV:** By fiction (mass, range, warding).
- **Hit:** Relocate within listed range; state any tells or costs (SB, Fatigue).
- **Partial:** Arrive off-balance, drop gear, or suffer worse Position.

[CONJURE] – Create a useful object, cover, or hazard.

- **DV:** By fiction (size, complexity).
- **Hit:** Conjure an item or zone with Integrity Clock [2/4/6] (if destructible) or a ticking hazard (burn, freeze, haze).
- **Partial:** Fragile or short-lived (lasts one exchange).
- **Countered by:** [DISPEL], force, time.

18.10 Outsider-Specific Tags

[WARD] – Challenge Outsiders crossing a warded edge or zone.

- **DV = target Cap.** (Cap is the Outsider's tier: 1 for Lesser, 3 for Greater.)
- **Hit:** Crosses; add +DV segments to its Leash.
- **Partial:** Crosses; add +1 segment.
- **Miss:** Cannot cross this beat.

[BANISH] – Drive a visible Outsider toward departure.

- **DV = target Cap.**
- **Hit:** Add +DV to its Leash.

- **Partial:** Add +1.
- **Miss:** No effect.

[UNWARD] – Unmake or suppress a **[WARD]** created by a Talent, Ability, or Spell.

- **DV:** By fiction (strength of the ward).
- **Hit:** Dismiss or suppress per source text.
- **Partial:** Weaken or suppress briefly (one exchange).
- **Miss:** No effect.

18.11 Elemental Backlash Coloring (Quick Reference)

When a magical roll generates SB (1s) or when a Partial/Miss occurs, the GM may apply a thematic backlash based on the dominant element(s). Use this table for inspiration:

11	
Element Minor / Major Backlash Examples	
Earth	Rubble, pin, heavy footing; vs Air: sound carries, exposure
Fire	Burns, flares; vs Water: slick, sputter, dim
Air	Scatter, drop, vertigo; vs Earth: stuck, dust choke
Water	Leak, flood, cold drag; vs Fire: smoke, shorted gear
Fate	Options close, "only one way"; vs Fortune: mischance hits ally
Fortune	Side-effect elsewhere, fragile success; vs Fate: harsher fixed outcome
Life	Overgrowth, fever; vs Death/Dreams: numbness, sleep-tug
Death/Dreams	Fade, threshold opens/closes; vs Life: pain returns, rot

18.12 Stacking & Duration Rules (Global)

- **No Same-Source Stacking:** Multiple scene-long effects from the same source do not stack; take the best instance.
- **Identical Tag Collision:** If two abilities would grant the same Tag in the same window, use the stronger; the weaker is suppressed while it lasts.
- **Default Duration:** Scene, unless a source states otherwise (e.g., "until the end of your next turn").
- **DV by Fiction:** Potency, preparation, place, materials, and opposition set DV (typical 2–4; 5+ for set-pieces).

19 Backlash, Obligation, and Ritual Consequences

Magic is never free. This section codifies the three main risk currencies: **Backlash** (for free casting), **Obligation** (for Rites and Patron dealings), and **Ritual Consequences** (for invokers and universal rituals).

19.1 Backlash (Free Casting)

Backlash is the unpredictable fallout from shaping raw magic. It occurs when a casting roll (Weave or Cast) yields a **Partial** or **Miss**, or on a **Hit that shows two or more 1s** (minor backlash alongside success).

Backlash Menu (choose one on Partial, two on Miss)

- **Position Shift:** Your Position worsens by one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate) for your current or next action.
- **Fleeting Harm/Condition:** Minor injury (1 Fatigue or Harm 1) or a temporary Condition (Dazed, Singed, Disoriented).
- **Exposure/Noise:** Draws unwanted attention – guards alerted, a door slams, a rival notices.
- **Resource Drain:** Lose a component, a tool wears out, or you mark 1 Fatigue.
- **Collateral Spark:** A nearby ally, object, or environmental feature is threatened (GM describes).

All backlash is **colored by the dominant element** (see Elemental Backlash table, §10). The GM spends Story Beats (generated by 1s) to apply these consequences.

19.2 Obligation (Rites and Patrons)

Obligation measures a Patron's claim on a character. It is tracked per Patron as a clock (default 6 segments).

Marking Obligation

- **Invoking a Rite (Runekeeper):** Mark the Rite's listed Obligation (typically +1).
- **Pushing a Rite:** Mark an additional +1 Obligation.
- **Cross-Patron Interference:** Using Rites from two different Patrons in the same scene marks +1 Obligation to the second Patron.

Obligation Capacity and Overflow Obligation Capacity = Spirit + Presence. If total Obligation exceeds Capacity:

- Mark 1 Fatigue per segment over Capacity.
- You cannot invoke new Rites or perform Patron rituals until Obligation is reduced below Capacity.

Clearing Obligation

- **Off-screen:** Perform an Act of Service aligned with the Patron (provide an Intricate Description). Clear 1 segment.

- **On-screen (Focused Devotion talent, 3–5 XP):** Once per scene, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 segment (cannot clear segments accrued in the same scene).

19.3 Ritual Consequences (Invokers and Universal Rituals)

Rituals (slow, significant-time workings) carry their own risks beyond ordinary casting.

Invoker Rituals (via Symbol)

- **Ritual Completion:** Always marks +1 **Obligation** (attention cost).
- **Crack the Seal (Instant Cast):** Mark +2 **Obligation** (+3 for High Rites); the Symbol becomes COMPROMISED (inert until restored). The GM may immediately spend 1 SB on-theme.
- **Restoring a Symbol:** Downtime action + test (DV 3, Arcana or Lore). Success returns to Maintained; shaky success leaves it Neglected (future rituals +1 Obligation).

Universal Rituals (any character)

- **Failure / Partial:** The GM may impose a consequence from the Backlash Menu (see above) or a narrative twist (wrong spirit answers, ward backfires).
- **Components:** Rare components may be consumed on a Partial or Miss.

Symbol Overload and Rivalries

- **Multi-Symbol Overload:** Carrying 4+ different Symbols causes the first Invoker ritual each scene to mark +1 additional Obligation.
- **Rival Symbols:** Displaying a rival Patron's Symbol while invoking another worsens Position by 1 and marks +1 Obligation to the current Patron. On any rolled 1, the GM may trigger a Patron omen/glitch.

19.4 Interruption and Counterplay

- [COUNTER] can interrupt a Weave, Cast, Rite, or ritual within its casting window (DV by fiction).
- [DISPEL] ends or suppresses ongoing magical effects (DV by fiction).
- [UNWARD] suppresses/dismisses [WARD]s; [BANISH] and [WARD] interact with Outsiders per §10.

19.5 GM Budget Dials

- **SB Budgets:** Use scene/session limits (see Complications, §7).
- **Obligation Pace:** Expect 2–4 segments marked per session for an active Runekeeper.
- **Backlash Visibility:** Favor big, legible consequences over many minor pinpricks.

19.6 Micro-Examples

Free Casting Backlash *Lyra casts a fire bolt (Weave + Cast). Partial on the Cast roll with two 1s. The GM spends SB: "The bolt hits, but the flash blinds you – your next action is Desperate. Also, the smoke triggers a hanging lantern; the room starts catching fire (Clock: Fire Spread [4])."*

Runekeeper Push and Debt *Kael invokes the Sealed Gate's Circle of Denial [WARD] and Pushes It to harden the ring. He marks +1 Obligation for the Rite and +1 for the push (total +2). Later, a demon tests the ring – the GM uses the [WARD] rules (DV = demon's Cap). On a Hit, the demon crosses, adding +DV to its Leash.*

Crack the Seal Under Fire *Vex presents Ikasha's Symbol and Cracks the Seal to lay an instant shadow lane. Symbol becomes Compromised; she marks +2 Obligation. The GM immediately spends 1 SB to dim all lights (panic). Later, during downtime, Vex restores the Symbol with an Arcana test (DV 3) – a shaky success leaves it Neglected until she performs a full rite of cleaning.*

20 Character Creation & Starting Build

20.1 Starting Build Points

Players begin with **30 XP** to allocate during initial character creation. This represents a balanced baseline for competent starting characters.

20.2 Enhanced Starting Builds

Players may exceed the standard 30 XP build through narrative engagement:

- **Bonds:** Up to two player-defined mutual bonds may be taken for **+2 XP total**. (See Bonds and bond-driven play in the core rules.)
- **Complications:** Up to two initial complications may be accepted for **+4 XP total**. *Note:* Scenes start with **+1 banked SB per complication per character** until those complications have cleared.

This allows a maximum starting build of **34 XP**. Players are encouraged to aim for 30 XP and use bonds/complications to enhance characterization rather than pure mechanical optimization.

20.3 Recommended Approach

GMs should encourage players to:

- Target 30 XP for balanced starting characters.
- Use bonds and complications to enhance characterization rather than pure mechanical optimization.
- Consider the narrative implications of any starting advantages.

20.4 Initial Complications (Reminder)

For each *initial complication* taken at character creation:

- Start each scene with **+1 banked SB** *per character with initial complications* until those complications have cleared in play.

20.5 Early Talent Choices (Magic Access)

- **Spellcraft (6 XP)**: Required for Weave & Cast freeform magic. Provides flexible but limited effects with elemental backlash.
- **Familiar / Thiasos (2 XP)**: Required for Patron features such as *Patron's Gift* (Imbuements).
- **Codex (4 XP)**: Required to fully join a Patron's service as a Runekeeper (Rites access, Obligation). A Runekeeper may serve only one Patron.
- **Patron's Symbol (4 XP)**: Minor Asset. Grants ritual access to a Patron's Rites via the Invoker path. One Symbol per Patron; Invokers may carry Symbols of multiple Patrons.
- **Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)**: Required for summoning spirits. Then *Lesser Pactwright* (2 XP) for Cap 1 spirits, *Greater Pactwright* (4 XP) for Cap 3.

20.6 Quick Build Guides

Caster (Freeform) Buy **Spellcraft (6 XP)**. Invest in Arcana-adjacent attributes/skills. Expect backlash; leverage aligned elements, tools, and preparation for DV/Effect nudges.

Runekeeper (Rites User) Acquire **Familiar (Thiasos)** (2 XP) and **Codex (4 XP)** tied to a single Patron. You may Push Rites for +1 Obligation. Use *Patron's Gift (Imbuement)* once per scene (1 action). The Gift provides **+1 Melee** and **+1 Thematic Skill** (fixed by Patron).

Invoker (Symbol Path) Purchase one or more **Patron's Symbols (4 XP each)**. Each Symbol grants ritual access to that Patron's Rites.

- **Ritual Invocation**: Takes DV+1 rounds and always marks +1 Obligation.
- **Crack the Seal**: Cast instantly by setting the Symbol to COMPROMISED and marking +2 Obligation (+3 for High Rites).
- **Multiple Symbols**: Invokers may hold Symbols from multiple Patrons; each Symbol tracks its own state.

Summoner (Pact-Whisperer) Take **Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)**. Call a spirit (1 action), Bind it by spending 1 Boon or marking 1 Fatigue. Track its **Leash = Cap + Spirit** segments. The Leash ticks when the spirit takes harm, you split focus, you order it against its nature, rivals contest it, or it crosses a [WARD]. Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick (Boon Finesse). Limit one active spirit at a time (or more with talents). Spirits depart at downtime unless an ability states otherwise.

Cantor (Songs) – Optional Requires **Cantor’s Path (8 XP)** (see full rules). Perform Low Rites as Songs; track Corruption instead of Obligation. Not recommended for first-time players.

20.7 Session Zero Tips

- Establish the table’s tone and stakes; tie Drives to setting fronts.
- Map Bonds among PCs; mark possible bond-driven Boon triggers.
- Seed 1–2 personal Complications per PC for early spotlight.
- Discuss Patron choices, Gifts, and what their omens look like.

21 Advancement & XP

Advancement in Fate’s Edge reflects meaningful growth in capability and standing. XP is awarded for table-facing accomplishments, hard choices, and the dramatic friction that defines your story.

Boons can be converted sparingly to accelerate growth.

21.1 Awarding XP

Choose a session pacing dial and stick to it for a campaign arc.

Gritty:

4–6 XP per session (slow burn).

Standard:

6–10 XP per session (default pace).

Heroic:

10–14 XP per session (fast growth).

21.1.1 Session Awards (Guidelines)

- **Table Attendance:** +2 XP
- **Major Objective Reached:** +2–4 XP
- **Discovery or Lore Unlocked:** +1–2 XP
- **Hard Choice Embraced:** +1–2 XP
- **Complication Spotlight:** +1–3 XP
- **Bond/Flag Driven Play:** +1–2 XP
- **GM Curveball Award:** +0–3 XP

21.1.2 Milestones

- At the conclusion of a major story arc, award **+8–12 XP to all players**.
- Grant **+2 XP** to one player for a signature moment of the arc.

21.1.3 Boon Conversion

Once per session, during downtime, a character may convert **2 Boons** → **1 XP** (max **2 XP** via conversion per session). All normal Boon limits apply (hold 5; trim to 2 at scene end).

21.2 Spending XP

Attributes:

Cost = *new rating* × 3. Downtime = *new rating* in days.

Skills:

Cost = *new level* × 2. Downtime = *new level* in days.

On-Screen Followers:

Cost = *Cap*². Downtime = 1–3 days to recruit and brief.

Off-Screen Assets (Minor/Standard/Major):

Minor (4 XP, 1 day), Standard (8 XP, 1 week), Major (12 XP, 1 month).

Talents/Minor Assets:

As listed (e.g., Spellcraft 6 XP; Patron's Symbol 4 XP).

21.3 Upkeep

Upkeep is paid once per Downtime period per asset or follower.

- **Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time)** – Cost: Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \lceil \frac{\text{Acquisition XP}}{3} \rceil)$. Minimal effort.
- **Intensive (Lower XP, More Time)** – Cost: 1 XP. Requires a dedicated Downtime action with significant personal involvement.

Failure to pay: The resource degrades:

- *Follower:* Becomes **Wary** (or **Seized** if already Wary).
- *Asset:* Becomes **Neglected** (or **Compromised** if already Neglected).

21.4 Rush Rule

When you buy or upgrade an ability during downtime, you may skip the normal training time. The GM creates a **Haste clock [4]**. If the clock fills (e.g., from missed rolls or complications), the new ability or asset carries flaws or narrative hitches. (See Training and Development Time in the full rules.)

21.5 Tiers of Reputation

Reputation tiers reflect how the world responds to you.

Tier I — Rookie (0–40 XP):

Local reputation; prestige locked.

Tier II — Seasoned (41–90 XP):

Regional notice; prestige abilities may unlock.

Tier III — Veteran (91–150 XP):

National influence; second follower slot suggested.

Tier IV — Paragon (151–220 XP):

Movers and shakers; rivals emerge to challenge.

Tier V — Mythic (221+ XP):

Legendary status; kingdoms and cults respond.

High-Tier Play and Boons As characters advance, the role of **Boons** shifts. At early tiers, Boons primarily buy *reliability* – negating Fatigue, stabilizing risky actions, or nudging Position. At higher tiers, Boons increasingly buy *authority*. A single Boon may force a truth, seal a pact, redirect consequences, or resolve a phase of a conflict outright.

High-tier characters typically have *fewer Boons to rely on*, but each spend carries greater narrative weight. This is intentional. Power at high tier comes from preparation, Bonds, oaths, and hard choices – not from inflating Difficulty Values. The world does not become harder to roll against simply because characters are stronger; instead, success and failure both reshape the story in larger ways.

21.6 Advancement Notes

- Attribute cost scaling encourages diversification over single-stat spikes.
- Skill mastery yields tangible, fiction-first benefits.
- Prestige abilities (6+ XP) should be gated by narrative milestones or patron bargains.

22 Range & Position Quick Reference

This section condenses the guidance from earlier chapters into table form for fast table use.

22.1 Range Bands

@llp8.5cm@

Band Default Notes

Close Touching Grapples, knives; polearms from Near at Limited Effect.

Near Assumed Same room/street segment; quick step away.
 Far Distant Same site but not in reach; needs time/route/long implement.
~~Absent Off screen Outside scene frame; needs cut or travel to interact.~~

22.2 Movement (beats, not meters)

- **1 Move** shifts one band: Close↔Near or Near↔Far.
- **Dash (Action)** shifts two bands: Close→Far or Far→Close.
- **Charge / Skirmish (full turn, costs 1 Fatigue)**: move two bands and attack (melee or ranged). Requires open ground unless you have the *Relentless* talent.
- **Terrain/Obstacles** may add +1 Move or require a test first.
- **Absent↔Scene**: use a Travel clock [2–4] or a quick cut; under pressure treat as Controlled.

22.3 Melee Flag

Mark two parties **in Melee** when they are in Near and directly engaged.

- **Enter**: 1 Move from Near (Controlled if under fire).
- **Leave**: 1 Move to break off; if threatened, must take the **Disengage action** (Action, not Move). Without Disengage, leaving Close range provokes a free opportunity attack.

22.4 Targeting & Tools (defaults)

@lp10.5cm@

~~Type Default Reach / Off-band Rules~~

Melee/Touch Close only (Near on long polearms at Limited Effect).
 Thrown / Short magic Near; at Far impose Limited Effect or +1 DV unless source says otherwise.
 Firearms / Long bows / Line spells Near and Far if stated; at off-band, reduce Effect or +1 DV.
 Social Near by default; at Far need voice/signal/proxy; at Absent need message/oath/setup.
~~No line of sight Raise DV by +1, drop Effect one step, or require [REVEAL]/[MARK].~~

22.5 Perception, Stealth, Cover

- **Notice**: Near normal; Far harder (DV +1 or Limited Effect) especially with noise/cover.
- **Hide**: Break line of sight or move to Far; at Absent you are off-frame unless tracked.
- **Cover**: Improves Position or reduces consequence severity; quality/angle sets the bump.

22.6 Position (Dominant / Controlled / Desperate)

Position affects consequence severity on Partial/Miss (not DV directly).

- **GM Spend (1 SB)**: Shift Position one step worse for current action or apply a brief environmental shove.

- **Player Spend (1 Boon):** Shift Position one step better for current action or cancel a single 1-step GM shift.
- **Narrative Triggers (free):** Flanking, reinforcements, collapsing cover, superior leverage can move Position one step (say why).

Limits: One Boon shift per action. Multiple forces do not stack beyond one step each way – resolve in order declared.

22.7 GM Quick Cues

- Default to **Near** and **Controlled**. Ask: "Do you need a beat to get there?" If yes, spend a Move.
- Call **Melee** when knives are actually in play; don't track hexes or squares.
- Prefer one strong twist over nickel-and-diming with many petty penalties.

23 Travel Framework

Journeys are more than distance; they are sequences of pressure, discovery, and consequence. The travel framework turns long roads into a series of dramatic legs without micromanaging miles.

23.1 Legs and Travel Clocks

- Break a long journey into **legs**, each representing a significant change in terrain, danger, or political region.
- Each leg uses a **Travel Clock** (default size 4 segments).
- The clock advances through **progress actions**, **encounters**, or **scene resolution**.
- When the clock fills, the party arrives at the destination (or the next region). Unresolved complications carry forward.

23.2 Roles on the Road

Assign one role per character each leg. Roles may rotate each leg.

Guide:

Sets course, reads signs, rolls navigation. On a success, tick the Travel Clock +1.

Scout:

Moves ahead; first contact with hazards or ambushes. On a success, the party cannot be surprised on the first encounter of the leg.

Quartermaster:

Manages supplies and encumbrance. On a success, prevent one Supply drop or recover 1 spent Supply.

Watch:

Maintains vigilance. On a success, the party gains +1 Position on the first defense roll of any ambush.

Each role action requires a roll (Attribute + appropriate skill, DV set by the GM). Failure may tick the Travel Clock backwards or introduce a complication.

23.3 Encounters & Events

Every 1–2 segments filled, the GM introduces an encounter or hazard. At minimum, each leg should include **one meaningful encounter**.

- **Discovery:** Ruins, strange omens, hidden sites.
- **Hazard:** Terrain challenge, illness, extreme weather (see §?? for hazard clocks).
- **Encounter:** Bandits, emissaries, beasts, or rival travelers.
- **Complication:** Bond tested, supplies strained, pursuit gains ground.

Encounters use the standard resolution loop (Position, DV, Outcome). On a failed travel roll, the GM may spend SB to introduce an encounter immediately.

23.4 Supply & Depletion

Track shared party supplies with a **Supply Clock [4]**.

- Tick the clock when the Quartermaster fails a roll, when the GM spends SB on scarcity, or when the party is forced to march without resupply.
- When the clock fills, the party runs out of a critical resource (food, water, fuel). Apply a Condition (*Hungry*, *Thirsty*, etc.) or mark 1 Fatigue per character.
- Resupply at settlements, successful foraging, or by spending a Cache token (see Asset rules).

23.5 Optional: Regional Travel Decks

If using the optional **Regional Decks** (see full rules), draw a card from the destination's deck when the Travel Clock ticks. Suits suggest the nature of the encounter:

- **Spades:** Place – a landmark, ruin, or terrain feature.
- **Hearts:** Actor – a traveler, patrol, or local guide.
- **Clubs:** Pressure – weather, injury, resource loss.
- **Diamonds:** Leverage – a shortcut, a cache, or a friendly face.

Highest rank may set the Travel Clock size (e.g., 4 for 2–5, 6 for 6–10, 8 for J–K, 10 for A).

23.6 GM Quick Cues

- Travel should **advance story stakes**, not pause them. Use legs to foreshadow threats, deepen bonds, or reveal Patron omens.
- Let players showcase talents in their chosen roles.
- Mix discovery and hardship to keep legs tense but rewarding.

24 Deck of Consequences (Optional)

The **Deck of Consequences** is a narrative tool for injecting drama, setbacks, and twists. It replaces or supplements GM fiat with randomized complications that remain thematically consistent. Its use is entirely optional.

24.1 Deck Structure

Use a standard 52-card deck (jokers optional). Suits map to complication themes:

@llp8cm@

Suit Theme Examples

Hearts	Social / Emotional	Betrayal, scandal, broken trust, awkward moment, ally under strain.
Spades	Physical / Harm	Bruise, injury, collapse, gear damage, ambush.
Clubs	Material / Cost	Resource loss, gear failure, debt, ruined supplies, theft.
Diamonds	Magical / Spiritual	Omen, curse, Patron attention, reality bend, haunting.

24.2 Card Ranks & Severity

Ace:

Scene-altering twist; compels immediate response.

King/Queen/Jack:

Major complication with lasting effects.

10–8:

Moderate complication that reshapes the current scene.

7–5:

Minor complication; a nuisance that creates tension.

4–2:

Subtle complication or foreshadowing omen.

24.3 Jokers (Optional)

- Red Joker: Catastrophic event (environmental collapse, patron intervention).
- Black Joker: Dark boon (immediate help, but with lasting cost or debt).

24.4 When to Draw

The GM may draw from the deck when:

- A roll shows multiple 1s (e.g., three or more).
- The GM spends 2+ Story Beats at once.
- A major clock fills (scene or campaign clock).
- During travel (see §23) to generate an unexpected encounter.

Aim for 1–2 draws per session; more if the tone skews chaotic.

24.5 Integration with Fiction

- Translate the raw card result into a fiction-first complication. Do not apply mechanical penalties alone.
- The complication should build on what is already happening in the scene, not restart the story.
- Respect player agency – allow clever mitigation, but ensure the consequence lands.

24.6 GM Quick Cues

- Use the deck to surprise yourself as well as the players.
- If a card does not fit the current fiction, draw again or adjust the rank up/down by one.
- For campaign-scale foreshadowing, draw a card at the end of a session and note its theme; introduce the complication in a later session.

25 Player Archetypes at the Table

Fate’s Edge gameplay flexes to different player archetypes. These roles are not strict classes but rather **approaches to play** that help a group balance spotlight and tone.

25.1 The Solo

- **Focus:** Mastery of self, independence, one-on-one drama.
- **Strengths:** Quick spotlight scenes, duelists, scouts, specialists.
- **Risks:** Can drift into isolation or hog solo arcs. Needs explicit ties to group goals.
- **GM Tools:** Use Bonds, rival duels, and one-on-one omens to keep engagement tethered to the group.

25.2 The Mixed

- **Focus:** Hybrid adaptability – both support and lead.
- **Strengths:** Bridges gaps in group dynamics; excels in team tactics.
- **Risks:** May feel overshadowed by extreme specialists.
- **GM Tools:** Spotlight them when versatility matters: flexible magic, leadership, negotiation, or sudden pivots.

25.3 The Mastermind

- **Focus:** Schemes, plans, and command over the long arc.
- **Strengths:** Drives strategic play, coordinates others, excels in intrigue.
- **Risks:** May over-plan or dominate spotlight with metagame thinking.
- **GM Tools:** Challenge them with shifting information, Patron demands, and rivals who anticipate their moves.

25.4 Balancing Archetypes

- A healthy table mixes all three archetypes, ensuring solo tension, group cohesion, and strategic play coexist.
- Encourage players to flex between archetypes scene by scene; they are fluid, not fixed.
- Spotlight balance: in a 3-hour session, each archetype should anchor at least one major scene.

25.5 GM Quick Cues

- Use archetypes as a lens for framing scenes: duels for Solos, shifting tactics for Mixed, grand reveals for Masterminds.
- When spotlight imbalances arise, rotate complications or bonds to another archetype's strength.
- Archetypes inform how Patrons and factions court PCs: Solos as champions, Mixed as envoys, Masterminds as plotters.

26 Campaign Frame: The Crown Spread (Optional)

The **Crown Spread** is a campaign-framing tool that uses a spread of cards to establish the long arc of a story. It provides seeds for GMs and players to weave motifs, omens, and foreshadowed events. Its use is entirely optional.

26.1 Setup

- In Session 0 (or before the campaign begins), lay out 5–7 cards in a semicircle (the "Crown"). Use either the **Deck of Consequences** (see §24) or a standard card deck.
- Each card anchors a motif, omen, or looming event.
- Record the spread openly on a Campaign Sheet or digital log.

26.2 Interpreting the Spread

Position 1 (Root):

The underlying tension or theme of the campaign.

Position 2 (Crest):

A key faction or patron influence that will rise.

Position 3 (Crown):

The climax image or major confrontation the arc builds toward.

Position 4 (Left Hand):

A bond, ally, or relationship that anchors play.

Position 5 (Right Hand):

A rival, betrayer, or challenger who pressures the party.

Optional Positions 6 & 7:

Expansions for setting-wide twists (environmental, mystical, or political).

26.3 Using the Spread in Play

- Each drawn card becomes a **Foreshadow Clock [4]** attached to its motif. Advance the clock when events lean toward that omen (e.g., when the GM spends SB on related complications, when a major scene involves that faction, or when a travel leg passes through an area tied to the motif).
- When a Foreshadow Clock fills, the motif manifests concretely in play – a faction rises, a betrayer reveals themselves, a curse activates.
- Tie Spread cards to **Campaign Clocks** for pacing (see below).

26.4 Campaign Clock

The **Campaign Clock** tracks rising stakes across the entire arc.

- Default size: [8] segments.
- Advance the Campaign Clock when: multiple SB overflows in a session (e.g., three or more 1s on a single roll), when travel legs resolve with major cost (e.g., a character reaches Harm 2), or when Spread omens manifest concretely.
- When the Campaign Clock fills, the Crown confrontation arrives. Play through its fallout as the campaign climax.

26.5 Ending & Legacy

- After the Crown confrontation resolves, hold an epilogue session.
- Resolve any remaining Foreshadow Clocks as epilogue vignettes.
- Players may mark **Legacy Bonds** – new anchors for future campaigns or descendants.

26.6 GM Quick Cues

- The Spread is not a railroad – it foreshadows, not dictates.
- Reinterpret cards liberally as play evolves; symbols matter more than literal events.
- Remind players of their omens between arcs to build tension and payoff.

27 Tags & Outcomes Cheat Sheet

This section condenses common tags, outcomes, and modifiers into a one-glance reference. It supplements the full explanations in §18.

27.1 Core Outcome Matrix

	p2.8cm	p3.5cm	p8.2cm
	Result Meaning GM/Player Guidance		
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB=0	Clean Success	Intent achieved, no complication.	
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB $\geq$ 1	Success & Cost	Intent achieved; GM spends SB for complication.	
0 < Successes < DV	Partial	Progress with complication; player gains 1 Boon.	
Successes = 0	Miss	No progress; GM escalates with SB; player gains 2 Boons.	

27.2 Common Tags (Abridged)

	p3.5cm	p10.0cm
	Tag Quick Reference Effect	
	[AREA] Affects all in a zone; collateral risk.	
	[BANISH] Drive an Outsider toward departure; DV = target Cap.	
	[BARRIER] Creates cover/obstruction with Integrity Clock.	
	[BIND] Immobilizes target until broken.	
	[CLEANSE] Remove or suppress a Condition (poison, curse, etc.).	
	[COMMAND] Issue a clear order; resolve as social contest.	
	[CONJURE] Create a useful object, cover, or hazard.	
	[COUNTER] Interrupt a spell or rite in progress.	
	[CURSE] Inflict a sticky hindrance with a clear release condition.	
	[DISPEL] End or suppress an ongoing magical effect.	
	[FORTIFY] Harden a target against a specific vector (fire, fear, etc.).	
	[MARK] Tag a target; once/scene +1 die against it.	
	[OATH] Bind parties to terms; breaking has teeth.	
	[PASSAGE] Declare a route as permitted or easy (improves travel).	
	[REVEAL] Expose illusions, disguises, or hidden clauses.	
	[SANCTIFY] Consecrate a zone to a code or Patron.	
	[SEAL]/[UNSEAL] Magically lock or unlock a container / door.	
	[TRANSPORT] Move a target across an obstacle (blink, lift, pull).	

	[UNWARD] Unmake or suppress a [WARD].
[VEIL]	Obscure a person, object, or zone (−1 die to Notice).
[WARD]	Blocks specific entities (DV = target Cap to cross).

27.3 Position & Effect Shorthands

- **Position:** *Dominant* (safe), *Controlled* (standard), *Desperate* (high stakes).
- **Effect:** *Limited* (weak), *Standard* (expected), *Great* (strong, extra reach).
- GM can spend 1 SB to worsen Position one step; player can spend 1 Boon to improve Position one step.

27.4 Backlash Reminders

- On Partial/Miss with Weave & Cast (Free Casting), expect backlash colored by the dominant element (fire burns, fate twists, etc.).
- Backlash does not add SB directly – it is a GM SB spend colored by the roll’s element.

27.5 Obligation Reminders

- Runekeeper Rite: Mark listed Obligation (usually +1); +1 more if Pushed.
- Invoker Ritual (via Symbol): Always +1 Obligation, even out of scene.
- Crack the Seal (instant cast): Mark +2 Obligation (+3 for High Rites); Symbol becomes Compromised.
- Multi-symbol overload: carrying 4+ different Symbols adds +1 Obligation to the first Invoker ritual each scene.

27.6 Magic Access Talent Costs (Quick Ref)

- **Spellcraft (6 XP):** Required for Weave & Cast freeform magic.
- **Familiar / Thiasos (2 XP):** Required for Patron’s Gift.
- **Codex (4 XP):** Full Runekeeper Rite access; Obligation applies.
- **Patron’s Symbol (4 XP):** Invoker ritual access (Minor Asset).

27.7 GM Quick Cues

- Default to **Near, Controlled, Standard Effect** unless fiction says otherwise.
- Use tags as handles for rulings – if a move fits the tag, apply its shorthand.
- Complications escalate campaigns; use Clocks and the Deck of Consequences for follow-through.

28 Design Philosophy Guardrails (Flow-First GMing)

Fate's Edge is built to **keep play flowing**. If you remember nothing else: **The Narrative is primary**. Mechanics exist to shape *how* the story changes, not *whether* it moves. This section translates the rules into plain, table-ready guidance – especially for new GMs.

28.1 Simple Translations

Story Beats (SB) ⇒ Story Beats:

1s on dice give you *beats* to spend. Spend them on twists, escalations, or new information. One strong beat is better than three tiny ones.

Clocks ⇒ Checkboxes/Lists:

A Clock is just a short checklist that tracks progress or rising danger. When it fills, the listed thing *happens*. Name it and tick it when fiction leans that way.

[TAGS] ⇒ Gates with a Cost:

Tags are labels that unlock specific effects (e.g. [WARD], [BANISH]). They don't do anything alone. They appear on Talents, Rites, or Spells to say, "Yes, you can do this – *here's the price and limits.*"

28.2 The 30-Second Adjudication Loop

Use this loop to resolve almost anything without breaking flow.

1. **Clarify intent and approach.** "What do you want, and how?"
2. **Set stakes and Position.** "If it works, what changes? If it fails, what bites?" Start *Dominant/Standard* unless fiction says otherwise.
3. **Roll & read.** Count 6+ as successes; each 1 gives you SB (beats). Compare successes to DV.
4. **Spend one beat well.** Cash SB on one memorable twist or tick a relevant Clock.
5. **Push forward.** Describe how the fiction is now different; ask, "Who moves next?"

28.3 When to Reach for Mechanics (and When Not To)

- **Roll** when uncertainty + meaningful stakes exist *now*. Otherwise, say "Yes" or offer a choice/cost.
- **Use a Clock** when danger or progress builds over time (guard alert, ritual, chase, social sway).
- **Draw from the Deck** when you want an oracular twist consistent with the current tone.
- **Skip subsystems** if they slow the table. You can always tick a Clock and move on.

28.4 Defaults That Keep Things Moving

- **Range/Position:** Assume *Near* and *Dominant/Standard*. Ask: "Do you need a beat to get there?"
- **DV:** 2 for small/local, 3 for scene-scale, 4 for big swings, 5+ for set-pieces/rituals.
- **Boons:** Misses on meaningful actions grant Boons (player fuel). Trim to 2 at scene end.
- **SB Budget:** Prefer one strong spend over many petty taxes. Bank sparingly and pay off soon.

28.5 Rookie GM Comfort Dials

You can use these dials to simplify play, then loosen them later.

Soft SB:

For your first 2 sessions, cap each roll's SB spend to **1–2** unless it's a set-piece.

Visible Clocks:

Put Clocks on the table. Name them aloud: "*Guards Incoming [4]*". Tick them in ink.

Tag Cards:

Print a one-liner for frequently used Tags ([WARD], [BANISH], [COUNTER]). Hand them out when a power is active.

One Move, One Sentence:

Every ruling should end with one sentence that states the new situation.

28.6 Narrative-First Rulings (with Examples)

Example 1: The Locked Gate Player: "I pick the lock fast before the patrol rounds the corner."
GM: "Dominant/Standard, DV 3. If it works, you're through; if it fails, the patrol clocks closer."
Roll shows 1 SB. GM spends 1 SB to tick *Guards Incoming [4]*. "You're through, but boots echo – two ticks left." *Flow continues.*

Example 2: The Shadow Rite Player Invokes a [WARD]. "You're safe unless Outsiders test the edge: DV = Cap. If one hits, its Leash gains +DV. Your Push would add +1 Obligation – do you Push?" The scene stays in motion; costs and gates are clear.

Example 3: Fire Cast Backlash Caster hits but shows two 1s. GM picks one strong backlash: "Flare blinds you; Position –1 for the next action." No rules dive – *one beat lands*, story moves.

28.7 Let the Fiction Lead

- Say what the world does next. If a rule is unclear, follow the fiction and note a ruling; refine between sessions.

- If you forget a tag nuance, ask: "What is the effect trying to *gate*?" Charge a cost (time, risk, Obligation, or a tick), then go.
- Tie SB spends to **visible** outcomes: a new foe appears, a path closes, a clock advances.

28.8 Common Pitfalls and Fixes

Over-cranking SB:

If scenes feel punitive, halve your SB spends for a while or cash them into visible Clocks instead of immediate penalties.

Clock Sprawl:

Merge redundant Clocks. Each active scene rarely needs more than **2–3**.

Tag Paralysis:

If a player stalls waiting for a perfect tag, paraphrase: "Sounds like [VEIL]. DV 3. Want to roll?"

Rules Drift:

If table memory conflicts with text, pick the ruling that keeps flow, then sticky-note a TODO to reconcile after play.

28.9 The Four Questions (Cheat Prompts)

When stuck, ask out loud:

1. If this goes right, what changes? (*Intent*)
2. If this goes wrong, what bites back? (*Stakes*)
3. What single twist will make this memorable? (*SB spend*)
4. Who moves next? (*Momentum*)

28.10 Design Guardrails (for Consistency)

- **Narrative Primacy:** Mechanics serve story, not replace it.
- **Risk as Drama:** Every roll carries potential for triumph+complication.
- **Meaningful Growth:** XP changes characters and the world.
- **Consequence Weight:** Choices ripple outward; nothing is free.
- **Fail Forward:** Misses fuel Boons; 1s become SB (beats).

28.11 Session Checklist (One Page)

Before play: set tone, stakes, and clocks in plain sight.

During play: adjudicate with the 30-second loop; spend one strong beat; move on.

After play: award XP, clear/advance Clocks, note rulings to revisit.

If you keep the flow, the game will carry you. The rules are rails you lay just ahead of the train.